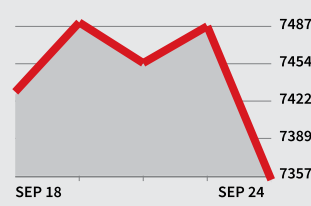


# the hindu businessline

**SENSEX** 73580.54 (-1247.71)



**IN FOCUS**

|                       | LATEST    | CHANGE  |
|-----------------------|-----------|---------|
| Nifty 50              | 23063.10  | -383.70 |
| P/E Ratio (Sensex)    | 19.53     | -0.34   |
| US Dollar (in ₹)      | 95.96     | +0.22   |
| Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹) | 150181.00 | -1226   |
| Silver 1 kg (in ₹)    | 228248.00 | -4518   |

## POLICY PUSH.

The draft National Energy Policy 2026 has been sent to the Union Cabinet for consultation, says Power Secretary Pankaj Agarwal **p3**



## UNDER THE LENS.

FSSAI drafts rules for crackdown on analogue *paneer* manufacturing and sale **p12**

## QUICKLY.

**LISTING GAINS**  
NSE ends a modest 2% up, but boosts BSE trading



**Mumbai:** The NSE listing turned out to be a blessing in disguise for the BSE. While NSE made a modest stock market debut, ending 2 per cent higher at ₹1,818 per share on Thursday, trading in the NSE counter generated ₹9,483 crore in turnover, accounting for nearly 32 per cent of BSE's overall turnover of ₹29,672 crore. BSE's total turnover more than doubled from ₹11,229 crore recorded on Wednesday, underscoring the impact of the high-profile listing. **p6**

## PRICE RELIEF

**Centre cuts import duty on palm, soybean oils**

**New Delhi:** The government has cut the import duty on crude and refined sunflower, soybean, and palm oil to reduce edible oil prices in the domestic market. The duty cuts are effective from Thursday. The basic customs duty (BCD) on crude soybean oil and palm oil has been slashed from 10 per cent to 5 per cent, and on refined soybean oil and palm oil from 32.5 per cent to 27.5 per cent. **p10**

# IRDAI reform ‘may force distributors to completely rethink business model’

**BIG CHANGE.** Can make insurance affordable, but cut in commissions can hit bancassurance earnings of banks

**Mithun Dasgupta**  
Kolkata

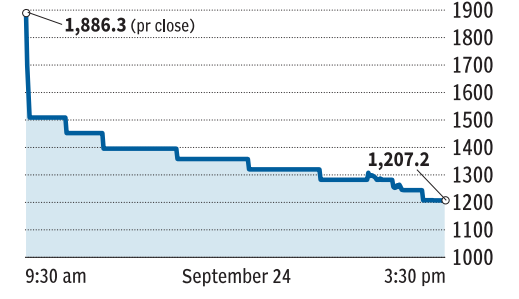
While insurance regulator IRDAI has proposed a major reform in distribution norms by sharply cutting commission payouts across products to bring down distribution costs and benefit customers, the steep cut could make insurance distribution unviable, forcing distributors to completely rethink their business models.

The proposed changes could also have implications for banks. As bancassurance commissions constitute an important source of fee income for many banks, particularly private lenders, any reduction in commission payouts can affect earnings from this business.

**EXPENSE MANAGEMENT** IRDAI, which released its much-awaited public consultation paper on insurance distribution reforms aimed at lowering policy costs and curbing mis-selling, said the purpose of these reforms is to facilitate better and more sustainable outcomes for all stakeholders, specifically policyholders. The consulta-

Finding the floor

PB Fintech (Intraday)



Collateral damage

|                     | Close (₹) | % change |
|---------------------|-----------|----------|
| Turtlemint          | 109.04    | ▼ 20     |
| Max Financial       | 1,410     | ▼ 9.8    |
| LIC                 | 406       | ▼ 0.4    |
| SBI Life            | 1,755     | ▼ 0.3    |
| HDFC Life           | 526.9     | ▼ 6.2    |
| ICICI Lombard       | 1,577     | ▲ 5.1    |
| New India Assurance | 180.4     | ▼ 5.6    |
| GIC                 | 339.25    | ▼ 1.4    |

tion paper proposes Expense of Management (EoM) for life insurance companies to be 15 per cent of their gross direct premium income (GDPI) in two years and 12.5 per cent in five years, and for non-life insurance companies, including standalone health insurance companies (SAHI), 20 per cent of GDPI in five years from 30 per cent now.

According to industry participants and analysts, the proposal would reintroduce commission caps across life, health and motor insurance that IRDAI had scrapped in 2023. It has proposed drastic cuts in first-year commissions across life savings and

term, health, and motor.

Commissions on health renewals and porting have been proposed to be cut drastically to 5 per cent in case of distribution entities and 10 per cent in the case of agents.

“IRDAI’s distribution consultation paper proposes stricter EoM limits for insurers, and 1/2-1/3rd commission cuts in health, term and motor insurance. This is a risk for PB Fintech/ Turtle-

mint, noting a 10 per cent cut in new business commission rates translates to a 10-12 per cent fall in their earnings,” Jefferies said in its report on Thursday. The brokerage, in its report, said SBI Life Insurance and LIC, with EoM ra-

tios of 10.6 per cent and 11.9 per cent, respectively, are comfortably placed. Others would need to reduce commissions to meet the new EoM threshold. “This could be a risk to near-term growth,

with insurers with strong agency better placed. Lower commissions could also result in banks (HDFC Bank, Axis) with open architecture pushing their key life insurance partners,” Jefferies said. Emkay Research, in its report, said the intent behind the proposed reform could be noble, to address the root cause of mis-selling and also to make insurance more affordable. “However, the drastic cut in distribution

commission would also make insurance distribution an unviable business and an unattractive vocation. And this could severely backfire, hurting the regulator’s growth agenda and Insurance for All by 2047.”

According to IIFL Capital, the banking system bancassurance pool of \$2.2 billion grew at 28 per cent CAGR in the last three years, constituting 10 per cent of banks’ fee income. “With relatively lower contribution from credit-life payouts, we think actual PAT impact is likely to be only low single-digit for banks,” it said in a report.

According to a top official at a large insurance distributor, the IRDAI reforms proposals reverse the 2023 Expense of Management changes and may increase compliance costs without benefiting policyholders.

However, Bejon Kumar Misra, International Consumer Policy Expert & EC Member, General Insurance Council, said the proposed distribution reforms are an important step towards making insurance more affordable, transparent and accountable to the policyholder.

# FinMin ‘will talk to IBA, others to ensure no MDR on consumers’

**Shishir Sinha**  
New Delhi

The Finance Ministry will work with the Indian Banks’ Association (IBA), traders, and other stakeholders to ensure that consumers do not bear the burden of the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI payments.

“The plan is to talk to the IBA and others to ensure that MDR is not passed on to the consumers,” a top Finance Ministry official said.

At the same time, the government is planning an outreach programme to clear doubts and ensure a smooth rollout of the new mechanism, which takes effect on October 15. “We are going to talk to trader bodies, such as the Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT), to bring them on board,” the source added.

## FUNDING GAP

Asked whether 0.4 per cent or ₹300 (whichever is lower) MDR for transactions above ₹2,000 and a lower or flat fee for various other kinds of specified transactions would be sufficient to fund the cost, the source said: “It will not. The government will need to take a call and find a way for filling the



The new MDR mechanism will come into effect on Oct 15

gap.” Industry estimates indicate that maintaining UPI payment operations, server bandwidth, fraud prevention systems, and bank technical support cost around ₹20,000 crore annually.

Relying solely on budget allocations creates funding uncertainty and limits long-term technology investments by banks and fintechs. “Transitioning to a commercial, threshold-based model provides reliable capital for continuous technological innovation,” NPCI has already clarified.

The source also reiterated that the MDR is neither a tax nor a cess/surcharge. “Not a single rupee of MDR goes to the government. MDR stays within the payment ecosystem,” the source added.

The GST Council is likely to review the 18 per cent GST on MDR, the source said.

# SEBI board clears comprehensive overhaul of portfolio management services, settlement rules

**Akshata Gorde**  
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Thursday approved a broad set of regulatory changes covering portfolio management services (PMS), settlement proceedings and foreign portfolio investor participation in commodity derivatives, alongside measures aimed at easing compliance and attracting foreign capital.

## COMMON AD CODE

The SEBI board also cleared a common advertisement code for regulated entities, depository receipts on REIT and InvIT units, changes to the accredited investor framework and easier norms for REITs, InvITs and debt issuers.

The common code will cover brokers, mutual funds, portfolio managers, investment advisers and research analysts, and allow celebrity



endorsements for brand-level promotions.

SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said the regulator has received over 3,500 comments on its proposed changes to the closing auction session (CAS). On brokers’ concerns over merchant discount rate (MDR) on UPI transactions, he said SEBI was looking at how it could represent their concerns, while brokers have also approached the government.

On margin trading facility (MTF), Pandey said the segment has grown over the past two years with the top 25 stocks accounting for about

20 per cent of the book. SEBI remains watchful of the risk-management framework, he said.

## PMS CHANGES

Among the key board decisions was a complete overhaul of PMS regulations. Portfolio managers will be allowed to invest in IPOs and primary debt issuances, up to 10 per cent of a client’s assets in investment-grade unlisted debt with consent, and up to 1.25 times the client’s AUM in exchange-traded derivatives. They can also invest in specified foreign securities.

A new Portfolio Managers Route for Investing in Mutual Fund units (PRIM) will allow portfolio managers to invest client money in direct plans of mutual funds, including ETFs, index funds and specialised investment funds. The minimum investment will be ₹25 lakh. SEBI also approved an Independent Fund Manager framework, allow-

ing qualified fund managers to manage portfolios under registered PMS entities.

## FAST SETTLEMENT

SEBI also revamped its settlement framework, introducing a pre-show-cause settlement notice with a 60-day application window. A fast-track mechanism will cover cases involving settlement amounts up to ₹10 lakh, while certain cases of financial misstatements and fund diversion may also be settled subject to conditions.

FPIs will now be permitted in non-agricultural index derivatives and non-cash-settled non-agricultural commodity derivatives, provided positions are exited before delivery obligations arise. The board also allowed depository receipts on REIT and InvIT units in IFSC and eased mandatory listing rules for outstanding unlisted NCDs.

Also read **p6, p7**

# Chandrasekaran’s third term as Chairman is valid, Tata Sons tells Noel Tata, citing former SC judges

**Aneesh Phadnis**  
Mumbai

Tata Sons has defended the re-appointment of N Chandrasekaran as Chairman for a third term, saying the resolution was validly passed.

Tata Sons justified the action in its response to Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata, who had called the resolution appointing Chandrasekaran illegal. While Noel Tata obtained Justice (retired) DY Chandrachud’s view, Tata Sons has relied on legal opinions from retired Supreme Court judges BN Srikrishna and Uday U Lalit to back its claims.

## CASTING VOTE

Article 121 of Tata Sons’ Articles of Association states that the appointment of the Chairman of the board re-

quires an affirmative vote of a majority of Trust-nominated directors present at the meeting. In case of an equality of votes, the Chairman will have the casting vote.

Justice Lalit opined that in the present case, out of five board members who cast their vote on the proposal, except Noel Tata, the other four had voted in favour of grant of chairmanship to Chandrasekaran. Since there was equality of votes among the Trust-appointed directors, the presiding or officiating chairman, by putting his casting vote, satisfied the requirement under Article 121.

While Justice Chandrachud is of the view that a casting vote exercised by the Chairman cannot supply a missing affirmative vote, Justice Lalit takes a different stance. He said there was certainly an occasion for the



Tata Sons has relied on legal opinions from retired SC judges BN Srikrishna and Uday U Lalit to buttress its claims **PTI**

chairman to have a casting vote as there was an equality of votes among Trust-nominated directors. “In my view therefore, the resolution dated September 17, 2026 for approving the agenda was validly passed,” he said.

## IN SPIRIT OF ARTICLES

Justice Srikrishna opined that the board’s action is perfectly consonant with the letter and spirit of Article 121.

“In my opinion, the proceedings before the board were not intended to be deadlocked in any event, and that is why it is necessary to read this article in a manner so as to ensure that the proceedings before the board and the querist’s business are taken forward and satisfactorily concluded,” he said.

He added that every director has two duties — one his fiduciary duty to the company under the Companies Act and the other to the nominating entity. “There is no doubt that the former duty must override the latter in case of a conflict. That is because the former duty is statutory and the latter is only contractual. In the circumstances, Venu Srinivasan (Tata Trusts nominee) rightly acted pursuant to the statutory fiduciary duty,” he said.

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Taking stock

Listing will, hopefully, improve governance at NSE

The listing of the National Stock Exchange on Thursday marks a watershed moment in the evolution of India’s capital markets. The country’s largest stock exchange in equity trading finally made its stock market debut, nearly a decade after it first sought permission from the stock market regulator to list.



While this gives investors an opportunity to own a slice of the largest Indian stock exchange, it is hoped that the higher public scrutiny following listing will lift its less-than-inspiring corporate governance practices.

NSE is the dominant stock exchange in India with 93 per cent share in cash trades and around 72 per cent share in the fast-growing index options segment. The high volume of transactions on its platform propelled it to the top globally among multi-asset exchange groups in FY26, with over 51.2 per cent share in global equity derivative contracts traded and 11.4 per cent share of global cash trade. Trading turnover at NSE has shown strong growth since the pandemic. It is, therefore, not surprising that the initial public offer of ₹22,562 crore, the second largest after Hyundai Motors India, was subscribed 5.69 times, led by demand from institutional investors.

Given the exchange’s strong technological infrastructure, potential to improve market penetration, and possible demand from passive funds once the stock is included in the benchmark indices, investors appear to be betting on the long-term prospects of the stock. That said, investors should not ignore the elephant in the room, namely the threat emerging from regulatory actions. Rampant speculation in the derivative segment with retail investors losing money heavily in the weekly index options had led to several regulatory tightening measures over the last two years, leading to a decline in revenues from the derivative segment. Further curbs are likely if speculation continues unchecked.

NSE was earlier mired in the colocation scam, where company insiders were alleged to have provided access to the exchange’s back-up servers in the colocation facility, giving a few traders unfair advantage over others. Many top officials of the exchange were named in the orders of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI). While NSE has settled the matter with SEBI by paying ₹1,491 crore, without admitting guilt, the overhang of the scam is likely to linger. The exchange has also been quite high-handed in communicating with investors and traders during technical glitches in its trading system.

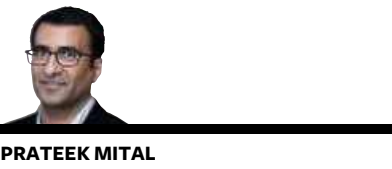
It is hoped that the wider public ownership will spur the NSE to set higher standards in corporate governance. The exchange will also have to take its role as a first-line regulator more seriously to curb unfair market practices. It must also strive towards building a robust market ecosystem by raising investor awareness on the futility of trading in futures and options, nudging them instead towards long-term investing in cash segment, or adopting the mutual fund route.

POCKET RAVIKANTH



AI redrawing the IT services map

BLEAK SCENE. IT firms will undergo a transformation of considerable scale and scope. The damage won’t be evenly shared



The pyramid model is gone. With coding agents, we no longer need basic coding — this blunt assessment comes from V Balakrishnan, the former CFO of Infosys. It is more than a prediction about entry-level jobs. For three decades, Indian IT services built scale by selling engineering capacity, measured largely through hours, utilisation and headcount. If AI can deliver the same work with fewer people, the industry isn’t simply becoming more productive. The economics of what it sells are changing. That change is already challenging the foundation of the model. Indian IT’s advantage was never just cheap labour; it also rested on scarce skills. AI now attacks both, cutting the hours many tasks require and reducing the scarcity of the skills behind them. Work that once required a specialist can increasingly be handled by a much larger pool of AI augmented generalists. When a scarce input becomes abundant, pricing power comes under pressure.

**ALL ABOUT MODELS** Nasscom President Rajesh Nambiar is right that AI may redraw India’s IT services map. But the claim that 20 to 25 per cent of firms could struggle to cross over tends to make a structural disruption look more bounded than it is. The harder question is how much of the existing model can survive while its replacement is being built.

AI also reduces the opacity around effort, letting clients ask why they’re paying for 10 days of work that now takes two. Under hourly billing, that efficiency gain flows to the client as a lower price, not to the vendor as margin. Pricing towards value delivered is the obvious response, but it shifts delivery risk onto the vendor and demands capabilities the old model never built.

AI creates three pressures at once: fewer hours, less scarcity in the skills behind them and a growing client ability to insure what they once bought. The third is the most disruptive since it threatens intermediation itself, not just delivery cost.

Pricing alone cannot fix this: shifting from hours to outcomes only captures value from work that still exists; it doesn’t guarantee that work, its pricing power, or the relationship will survive



MAN VERSUS MACHINE. The five largest Indian IT firms added a net 12,718 employees in FY25; in FY26 they shed 6,981

insourcing. Building an outcome-based business demands proprietary IP, domain expertise, customer intimacy and delivery risks the old model never had to carry. “Sell outcomes, not people” is an attractive answer. It is not a complete one.

**NO FUTURE?** The old revenue model can weaken before the new one becomes viable: legacy revenue disappears quickly, while proprietary platforms and outcome contracts take years to build. A firm can do everything right and still fail if old revenue disappears faster than its replacement emerges.

Much of what passes for transformation today is automation, not redesign. A copilot writes code, an agent triages tickets and the process gets cheaper, but the organisation and pricing model underneath stay untouched. But redesign changes who owns the outcome and the risk, cannibalising the revenue that built the company’s success. Firms can automate without redesigning, then present one as

The harder question is how much of the existing model can survive while its replacement is being built

evidence of the other. Automation buys time. It does not guarantee a future.

Underneath sits a structural problem: the classic pyramid (many juniors, fewer seniors, thin leadership) was built to staff hours, not organise accountability for outcomes.

The five largest Indian IT firms added a net 12,718 employees in FY25; in FY26 they shed 6,981. AI is driving that reversal by attacking routine work at the base, while an outcome-oriented organisation needs a smaller, senior-heavy, domain-aware shape that takes years to build.

The people inside that flattening pyramid hear a reassuring half truth: AI won’t replace you if you learn to use it. Clients that once bought hours from Indian vendors are increasingly building their own Global Capability Centres and hiring talent directly since AI lets smaller teams deliver more. Some work simply moves employer. Some is automated. Some disappears. Some becomes more valuable because it demands judgment that’s hard to commoditise. “Jobs are just moving up the value chain” is inadequate: AI fluency protects the skill, not the job, when the business model itself is losing relevance.

Much of this stays underexamined because almost nobody is incentivised to say it plainly. A CEO has little reason to tell an earnings call that the core

business is shrinking; analysts and consultants have reason to keep the story optimistic. That may explain the appeal of the 20 to 25 per cent estimate, too: it gives a complex transition a reassuring boundary. The more useful question isn’t what percentage fails, but how much value disappears before replacement value emerges, and who captures it.

**DISLOCATION RISK** The real risk is dislocation: can the economy absorb displaced labour and capital as quickly as the old model releases them? A demand recovery won’t restore the old headcount-to-revenue link, and a client with its own GCC has little reason to rebuild it. The long-term outcome may be positive. The transition can still be brutal.

The harder questions are economic: how much revenue exists only because human effort is sold by the hour, what happens as clients insource that effort and whether replacement revenue can scale fast enough to matter. Indian IT can transform, and some firms will build businesses more valuable than what came before. But that doesn’t mean the industry will cross the bridge intact. AI may redraw India’s IT services map. The damage will not be evenly shared.

The writer is GM and Head, AI Lab, Hitachi India. Views expressed are personal

Reserve Bank likely to start a shallow rate hike cycle

Even with large large FCNR inflows, the rupee continues to weaken; a rate hike may help contain the pressure

Rajani Sinha

The RBI Governor’s tone in the last MPC meeting was relatively dovish, and the central bank indicated that they would look at a rate hike only if the inflationary pressure gets broad-based. Since the last policy, there have been some key developments that will impact the RBI’s policy decision in the upcoming meeting.

One, global crude oil prices have shot up sharply in the last fortnight, intermittently breaching \$100/bbl level. The US Federal Reserve has started the rate-hike cycle, while the BoJ and ECB continue with the hikes. There continues to be weakening pressure on rupee even with large FCNR flows. Moreover, the FCNR flows have resulted in large surplus liquidity in the system. The critical question is in this backdrop is: how do we view the RBI’s policy decision?

MORE RATE HIKES

We expect the RBI to hike policy rate by 25 bps in the October policy meeting, followed by another 25 bps rate hike in December. We expect the policy rate hike cycle to be shallow with total of

50-75 bps rate hikes. Inflationary concerns have aggravated with the latest spike in global crude oil prices. Average Brent crude oil prices jumped to \$101/bbl in September from an average of \$85/ bbl in the previous three months. This has led to increased inflationary concerns in the economy. Poor monsoon has also led to concerns around rise in food inflation.

CPI inflation rose to 4.8 per cent in August from an average of 3.9 per cent in the April-June quarter. We expect CPI inflation to rise to 6 per cent by Q3 FY27, mainly led by food inflation. Food inflation has already touched a high of 5.7 per cent in August, and we expect it to further breach 7 per cent in Q3 FY27. WPI inflation has risen to an average of around 10 per cent in the last three months.

So far, threat to inflation was mainly due to supply-side bottlenecks, but we are seeing signs of CPI inflation getting broad-based. In August, around 19 per cent of the 358 items in the CPI basket recorded inflation above 6 per cent, up from 13 per cent in March. The CPI diffusion index, which measures the breadth of price increases across categories, rose to 72 from 44 over the same period. A reading above 50 indicates that



RBI GOVERNOR. Sanjay Malhotra is keeping an eye on inflationary pressures

more components are recording rising inflation than a fall.

GROWTH RESILIENT

While inflationary concerns have risen, the economy has been recording good growth. GDP growth in Q1 FY27 turned out better than market expectations at 7.8 per cent. The strong growth was supported by all pillars of the economy, with investment, consumption and exports recording healthy growth.

Even though there are threats from high global crude oil prices and US tariff-related hurdles, the economy has been showing strong resilience. While we anticipate GDP growth to moderate in the next few quarters, we still expect healthy growth at a little above 7 per

cent in FY27. Globally, inflationary concerns have escalated due to supply-side constraints. With rising US yields, the two-year India-US yield differential has fallen to 172 bps in September 2026, from 222 bps a year ago, and around 300 bps two years ago. This has been putting weakening pressure on the rupee. Even with the large inflows through FCNR deposits, the weakening pressure on the currency continues. A rate hike by the RBI may help contain the pressure on the currency.

FCNR deposits have resulted in a surge in liquidity in the banking system. It will be important for the central bank to ensure that the excess liquidity from the system is absorbed for any policy rate to be effective. We expect the continuation of OMOs and VRRR auctions that the RBI has been conducting to absorb excess liquidity from the system. The market would look for further guidance on additional measures, particularly CRR or I-CRR hikes, given the significant liquidity glut. Thus, apart from rate decisions, liquidity management would be a key highlight of the policy.

The writer is Chief Economist, CareEdge Ratings. Views expressed are personal

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Welcome step by FSSAI

This is with reference to ‘FSSAI Cracks Down on E-comm Sites for Misleading Claims’ (Sept 24). The FSSAI’s decision to initiate penal action against five e-commerce platforms is a welcome step towards protecting consumers in India’s rapidly expanding e-commerce market. The episode highlights a serious gap in the regulation of online marketplaces. E-commerce companies cannot treat themselves merely as passive intermediaries when they select, display, promote and deliver food products to consumers. FSSAI should mandate periodic audits of food listings,

stricter verification of sellers, rapid removal of prohibited products and clear disclosure of licences, ingredients, expiry dates and nutritional information. Platforms should maintain traceable records of sellers and products, and consumers, too, should check labels and report suspicious products.

Bal Govind  
Noida

AI’s accountability

This refers to ‘When Tech Takes a Backseat in Serving Humanity’ (Sept 24). Technology should ultimately strengthen human capability, not weaken human responsibility. The

rapid expansion of AI makes this distinction increasingly important. Schools and colleges should, therefore, teach students not merely to use AI tools, but also to question their outputs, protect privacy and recognise misinformation. Companies developing powerful systems must build transparency, accountability and safeguards into their products from the beginning. Governments, too, need clear rules without stifling useful innovation. Human oversight should remain central in areas involving education, employment, finance, healthcare and public services. The real measure of technological progress is not how

advanced a system becomes, but whether it improves people’s lives while preserving judgement, dignity and responsibility.

BA Neboba  
Erode, TN

Tense ties with China

The editorial ‘Future Tense - China-India Ties in a Renewed State of Flux’ (Sept 24) rightly brings out the complex relationship between the Asian giants. The repeated transgressions at the India China border by China since the 1960s gives Indian policymakers limited confidence in the prospects of a sustained period of partnership.

China has consistently supported Pakistan, including during Operation Sindoor, and even has a dubious deal with the country in POK. They continue to claim Arunachal as part of South Tibet. India has rightly said that unless the border aggression by China stops, trade deals cannot be taken forward. In parallel, India needs to develop alternatives to reduce its dependence on China and bring down the \$131 billion trade deficit. The US tariff threat is applicable for both countries, and it seems to have brought about some common ground for reconciliation.

Pradip Menon  
Kochi

## Next phase of Make in India

The focus must now shift to tech competitiveness

Chandrajit Banerjee

On September 25, 2014, India set a clear ambition: to make for India and make for the world. Twelve years later, Make in India has evolved from an initiative into a national manufacturing mission.

The vision of Make in India is backed by consistent and coordinated action on four pillars:

The first is ease of doing business. More than 47,000 compliances have been reduced as of November 2025, including 16,108 simplified, 22,287 digitised, 4,458 decriminalised and 4,270 redundant compliances removed. The Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2026 further strengthens trust-based governance by decriminalising 717 provisions and amending 784 provisions across 79 Central Acts.

### INFRASTRUCTURE PUSH

The second is world-class infrastructure. Dedicated freight corridors, 11 industrial corridors, Sagarmala and Bharatmala projects, and significant expansion of port and airport capacity have brought raw material closer to factories and factories closer to markets. PM Gati Shakti has added further coherence to logistics planning and reduced the logistics cost, making manufacturing in India competitive.

The third pillar is digital and tax reforms. GST created one national market, while ONDC and the Unified Logistics Interface Platform created one digital backbone.

This has been uniquely an Indian model — physical manufacturing powered by digital public infrastructure.

The fourth pillar is openness to investment. FDI limits were liberalised across defence, railways, insurance, construction and space, boosting access to global capital, technology and expertise. FDI inflows rose to ₹49.46 lakh crore during 2014–24, nearly double the ₹25.40 lakh crore in the previous decade.

A key enabler in this journey has been the Production Linked Incentive scheme. As of June 2026, the scheme has attracted ₹2.58 lakh crore in actual investment, ₹23.79 lakh crore in production and sales, and ₹15.53 lakh crore in exports, while supporting over 14.57 lakh direct and indirect jobs.

Support for MSMEs and startups has also remained



**NEEDED.** Stronger linkages between OEMs and MSME suppliers

central to the manufacturing journey.

Equally significant has been the growth of India's innovation and entrepreneurship ecosystem.

The signing of nine FTAs in six years spanning 38 countries has added further momentum by expanding preferential market access for Indian manufacturers and exporters across sectors.

CII has been advocating a focused agenda to Government for the next phase of Make in India. These would include:

**First, enhancing domestic manufacturing depth.** While final assembly has scaled, we must deepen value addition in components, raw materials, precision parts and capital goods, with stronger linkages between large OEMs and MSME suppliers.

**Second, cluster-based approach for exports.** India needs world-class manufacturing clusters with plug-and-play infrastructure, testing labs, logistics and worker housing, focused on export markets. Clusters in electronics, textiles, auto components, chemicals and engineering can reduce logistics cost and build scale for FTAs.

**Third, trust-based economic governance.** Non-Financial Regulatory Reforms (NFRR) and the Jan Vishwas Act cohesively build strategy for administrative simplification coupled with legislative decriminalisation. This should continue.

**Fourth, AI and automation for smart manufacturing.** Linking the AI Mission with manufacturing, creating shared Industry 4.0 facilities in clusters, and skilling workers for human-machine collaboration will help India move from cost competitiveness to technology competitiveness.

With new building blocks and focus on domestic depth, export clusters, financial reforms and smart manufacturing, we are strengthening the foundation for the next decade.

The writer is Director General, Confederation of Indian Industry



**AMIT KAPOOR**  
**DARSHANA GAURATRA**

India has become good at counting forests but the numbers conceal an important distinction. There is a difference between having more forest area and having more forest cover. FAO's Global Forest Resources Assessment (GFRA) 2025, for instance, stated that India ranks ninth globally in terms of Total Forest Area and third globally in Annual Net Gain of Forest Area. A gain in forest area does not necessarily mean a gain in forest cover and the same need not translate into a healthier forest ecosystem.

The Indian picture, however, looks remarkably different when the lens shifts to the other side of the spectrum. The recent CAG performance audit of the Green India Mission tabled in the Parliament on August 12 revealed that against a target of 1.4 million hectares, improvement in quality of forest cover was observed in only 0.11 mha. The increase in forest cover itself was even smaller, only 0.03 mha against the target of 1.4 mha. This stark contrast raises concerns beyond India's actual numbers.

### GIM FOCUS

The Green India Mission (GIM) is more than just a tree planting programme. It is one of the primary agendas of the NAPCC (National Action Plan for Climate Change) through which India seeks to increase forest and tree cover and ultimately enhance carbon sequestration and biodiversity. The 98 per cent shortfall is striking. However, this has also raised a more fundamental concern, as for ecological restoration, where a tree is planted is almost as important as whether a tree is planted. Even when trees were planted under GIM, 70 per cent of the sampled sites showed no improvement.

This is despite the existence of a dedicated GIS cell for monitoring the scheme. What is more troubling is that this is a pattern that is evident across India where a plantation is often being confused with restoration.

The plantation versus restoration matters particularly for India's climate commitments. The country committed to create an additional carbon sink of 3.5-4 billion tonnes of CO2 equivalent through additional forest and tree cover by 2035. However, a hectare of trees planted does not automatically convert to a tonne of carbon sequestered. Carbon storage relies deeply on what existed on the land before, the species selected, their survival, soil conditions, water availability and maturity of the ecosystem. The planting of trees on a piece of land is not the same as creating

# India's forest plans need a better architect

**GREEN COVER.** Ecological restoration cannot be managed like a construction target



GETTY IMAGES

an equivalent carbon sink to the atmosphere.

India's forest governance vastly depends on a similar implicit bargain, when a forest land is diverted for development, compensatory afforestation is taken elsewhere. The Great Nicobar Project seeks to transform the island into a strategic maritime and economic hub at the cost of diverting 1.82 per cent of pristine tropical rainforests. Since the island already has 75 per cent forest cover, the compensatory afforestation is planned kilometres away in an entirely different mainland, Haryana.

The logic may sound straightforward but ecological restoration does not work like balancing two columns in accounts. These incidents are also not isolated events. In Maharashtra, the State approved diversion of nearly 83,700 sq ft of forest land including reserve forests and mangrove land for a proposed cement terminal in Alibag. Similarly, large-scale felling of the protected Satbari area of the Delhi ridge in the capital for urban and infrastructure expansion led to penalty of 1.67 lakh trees. The missing element here is that

The planting of trees on a piece of land is not the same as creating an equivalent carbon sink to the atmosphere

the newly planted cannot immediately replicate the microclimate, soil composition or biodiversity of a mature natural green space. It merely satisfies an administrative requirement. Even when interventions were made under GIM, afforestation target of only 0.28 mha was achieved against the objective of 2.8 mha which was to be completed by 2018.

### IMPACT ON WILDLIFE

Another overlooked concern here is the consequences for biodiversity, particularly wildlife. It matters for wildlife that there is a continuous, useable habitat. The fragmentation of forest corridors has time and again shown that even when tree cover exists, interruptions in habitat reduce wildlife movement. Wildlife species depend on native vegetation, canopy structure, undergrowth, water availability and ecological connectivity that newly created monocultures will not be able to provide. An elephant or a tiger would not recognise a man-made boundary. It often appears as human-wildlife conflict, it is however more of a connectivity and unplanned restoration shortcoming.

This is the core weakness of treating forest cover or any ecological conservation more broadly, as a numerical target. For climate, biodiversity and restoration, geography is always part of the equation. India should also make far greater use of

existing satellites and geospatial capabilities it already possesses. If compensatory afforestation becomes the primary mechanism for producing more hectares on paper, it risks weakening rather than strengthening the environmental bargain underlying the forest diversion. Climate-vulnerability and biodiversity maps need to become part of the approval process.

The solution is not simply to provide a single mission with more money even though funding clearly matters. The mission received only around ₹1,149 crore in the 10 years of implementation counter to the estimated requirement of ₹10,600 crore. However, more money flowing through the same structural gaps would only mean more hectares without any substantial benefits. Survival rates, biomass growth, native-species recovery, soil and water conservations matter more than the number of saplings distributed.

The important lesson here is that any kind of ecological restoration cannot be managed like a construction target. It needs to move away from the idea of simply planting more trees. It needs to harness the skills of where a tree can deliver the greatest ecological value. The real audit is not how many trees it plants but how many functioning ecosystems it preserves.

Kapoor is chair, and Gauratra is researcher, Institute for Competitiveness

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

September 25, 2006

### Pawar steps in to resolve Bajaj Hind-Balrampur row

Having played mediator in the Bajaj family feud, the Union Agriculture Minister, Mr Sharad Pawar, is now engaged in ironing out differences between the country's top two sugar majors, Bajaj Hindusthan Ltd (BHL) and Balrampur Chini Mills Ltd. The issue under dispute is part of a no-holds-barred 'cane war' involving the two companies, which have been poaching into each other's turf.

### NTPC eyes direct sales to bulk users

NTPC Ltd is planning to unshackle the hegemony of State electricity boards (SEBs) in its customer base and is looking at direct sale of power to bulk consumers. The State-owned company — the country's largest power generator — is targeting at least five to seven per cent sale of electricity directly to industrial consumers over the next five years.

### Will talk to partners on divestment: PM

Steering clear of the controversial issue of sale of Government equity in PSUs, the Prime Minister, Dr Manmohan Singh, said the UPA would talk to its partners before revisiting disinvestment, which had been put on hold due to differences in the ruling coalition.

## US 30-year bond yield at over two-decade high

Alice Atkins  
Ruth Carson

Yields on the US's longest-dated bonds climbed to the highest level in more than two decades, the latest milestone in a global sell-off driven by inflation fears and concern about government debt burdens.

A fresh jump in oil prices on Thursday lifted the rate on 30-year Treasuries by as much as four basis points to 5.44 per cent, its highest since 2004. European yields were also on the rise, while those on Japan's government debt hit levels last seen in 1996 as the market reopened after a three-day break.

The average yield on government debt worldwide now stands within a whisker of 4 per cent, the highest since 2007, Bloomberg's Global Aggregate Treasuries index shows.

It's another reminder of the end of

the low-yield era as markets contend with the inflationary impact of the war in Iran, a robust US economy and a torrent of bond sales from governments and tech companies.

"It's rare you get a move like this in bonds," said Dave Aspell, co-chief investment officer at Mount Lucas Management LP, who is short 10-year bonds in the UK, Germany, Canada, Japan and the US. "The Fed has hiked again, inflation is clearly not at target. The economy is doing okay and there's a large amount of government spending."

The rise in borrowing costs is pressuring US President Donald Trump ahead of the November midterm elections, as dissatisfaction over lofty mortgage rates and the cost of living mounts.

He's called for US interest rates to be "1 per cent, or less" and criticised what he called a "hostile" Fed board for the



**CONTINUED RISE.** Undercuts efforts to bring down borrowing costs BLOOMBERG

decision to raise rates earlier this month.

Treasury two-year yields have climbed over 150 basis points since the start of the US-Iran war, while those on the 30-year are up over 80 basis points.

The continued yield rise undercuts the Treasury Department's efforts to bring down long-term borrowing costs: Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent

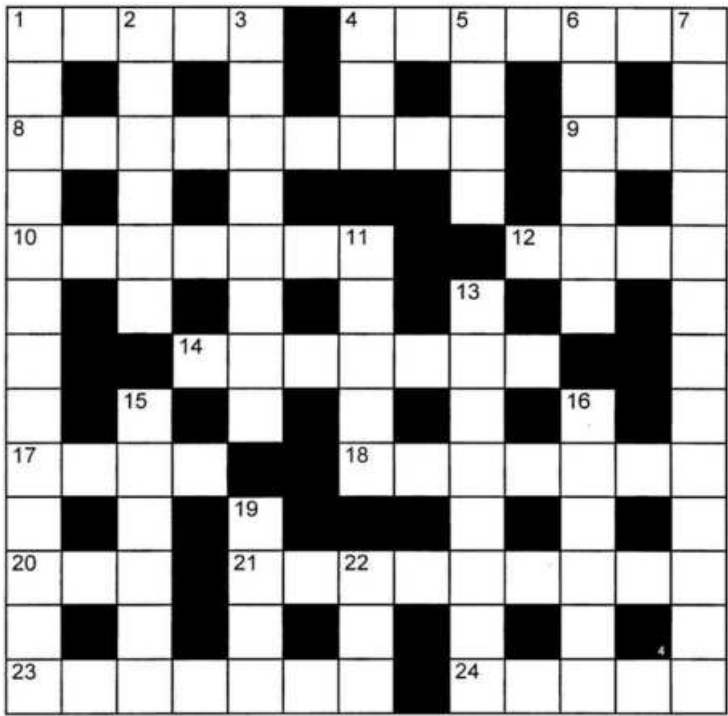
expanded the government's bond buyback program in mid-August in an effort to ease pressure — though it's had little sustained impact in the market.

A five-year US debt auction this week ranked as the second-worst by one measure in data recorded since 2018, drawing the highest yield since 2006 and showing the pressure on Washington as it faces the rising cost of servicing around \$40 trillion of debt.

Given the forces at play, "bonds are actually behaving rationally," said Amy Xie Patrick, a money manager at Pendal Group.

US five-year yields topped 5 per cent on Wednesday for the first time since 2007, while those on 10-year jumped the most since the Liberation Day tariff shock in April 2025. Strong economic data and surging oil prices prompted traders to ramp up bets on further Federal Reserve tightening. BLOOMBERG

## BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2743



### EASY

#### ACROSS

- Demonstrate clothing (5)
- Sick, giddy feeling (7)
- In one place or another (9)
- Head; fruit (3)
- One held for ransom (7)
- An impulse (4)
- The direction of a letter (7)
- Latin poet (4)
- Let air out of (7)
- A moral offence (3)
- A marine structure that's skeletal (5,4)
- Felt a longing for (7)
- Substance used in baking, brewing (5)

#### DOWN

- In a troublesome, cheeky way (13)
- Death of a distinguished person (6)
- The flatter regions of a country (8)
- To stand in rivalry with (3)
- Emit smoke, fumes (4)
- Take no notice of (6)
- At first glance (2,3,4,2,2)
- Was mistaken (5)
- Gainfully (8)
- Pigment that may be raw or burnt (6)
- Photographic apparatus (6)
- Cast eye over (4)
- A long, straight shoot (3)

### SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2742

**ACROSS** 2. Baste 5. Ogre 7. Omen 8. Railings 9. Gullible 11. Mine 12. Reconditioned 15. Less 17. Straying 19. Shepherd 21. Cuba 22. True 23. Twist

**DOWN** 1. Compute 2. Ban 3. Scrub 4. Evident 5. Obi 6. Regan 10. Looks 11. Moody 13. Dessert 14. Ennoble 16. Ether 18. Radii 20. Pie 21. Cut

QUICKLY.

Sonaselection India ends Day 1 with 5% premium



**New Delhi:** Shares of textile company Sonaselection India on Thursday listed over 3 per cent higher at ₹102 against the issue price of ₹99 on the BSE. The stock further jumped 8.17 per cent to ₹107.09 — the upper circuit limit — a gain of 5 per cent over the IPO price. On the NSE, the stock listed at ₹102.31 and closed at ₹107.42. The company's market value stood at ₹608.58 crore. The IPO of Sonaselection India was subscribed 2 times. The ₹141.6-crore IPO had a price band of ₹94-99 a share. Proceeds from the IPO will be used for debt payment, purchasing plant and machinery at the company's manufacturing facility and general corporate purposes. ■■

Inox Green launches QIP issue at ₹174.36 per share

**New Delhi:** Inox Green on Thursday announced the launch of its qualified institutional placement issue at a floor price of ₹174.36 per share. On July 22, the company's board had approved raising up to ₹600 crore through multiple financial instruments, including a QIP issue. The company's shares fell 0.20 per cent to close at ₹174.25 per share on BSE. In an exchange filing, Inox Green Energy Services said its committee of the board of directors on Thursday approved the floor price for the QIP issue at ₹174.36 per share (floor price). The company said it may, at its discretion, offer a discount of not more than 5 per cent on the floor price so calculated for the issue. ■■

# NSE ends 2% higher at ₹1,818 on modest listing, but lifts BSE volume

**BOOSTER DOSE.** NSE stock alone accounts for ₹9,483 crore, nearly 50% of BSE's cash segment turnover

Suresh P Iyengar  
Mumbai

The listing of NSE has turned out to be a blessing in disguise for BSE. While NSE made a modest stock market debut, ending 2 per cent higher at ₹1,818 per share on Thursday, against the IPO price of ₹1,785, trading in the NSE counter alone generated ₹9,483 crore in turnover, accounting for nearly 50 per cent of entire BSE equity trading turnover of ₹20,672 crore. The stock got listed at ₹1,800 and rose to a day's high of ₹1,878. In fact, BSE's total turnover more than doubled from ₹11,229 crore recorded on Wednesday, underscoring the impact of the high-profile listing.

NSE had raised about ₹22,569 crore through its initial public offering, which was priced at ₹1,785 per share. Ratiraj Tibrewal, Director, Choice Capital Advisors, said large IPOs typically have a sizeable pool of existing shareholders looking to sell once lock-in restrictions expire, which tends to cap upside in the initial months. "A muted listing on its own says very little. What happens over the next year will depend on earnings, not on day-one performance," he said. Investors are also closely watching whether derivatives volumes can sustain momentum following the securities transaction tax increase and whether NSE can arrest the decline in its share of the



**NSE@DALAL STREET.** (from left) Ashishkumar Chauhan, MD and CEO, NSE, Srinivas Injeti, Chairperson, with Sundararaman Ramamurthy, CEO, BSE, during the listing ceremony ■■

index options market, which contributes nearly 60 per cent of its revenue, he added.

Macquarie has initiated coverage on NSE with an Outperform rating and a target price of ₹1,965. The global brokerage views NSE as "The Dominator", citing its leading market share and power, while highlighting its

full set of services, technology stack and deep liquidity. Macquarie said NSE's superior fundamentals justify a premium multiple and sees room for further re-rating if new products accelerate. PL Capital has initiated coverage on NSE with a target price of ₹1,950. It expects revenue and PAT to grow at an annual rate of around 11 per cent each between FY26 and FY29. Asian Markets Securities said NSE is the bellwether of Indian exchanges. "Its strong liquidity and diversified revenue stream, with more than 90 per cent market share across products other than index options, are key moats that are difficult to replicate," it said while initiating coverage with a Buy call and a target price of ₹2,170.

## PB Fintech put options buyers rake it in

KS Badri Narayanan  
Chennai

Put option traders of PB Fintech, particularly buyers, have plenty of reason to smile on Thursday, as the premiums surged dramatically following the sharp decline in the underlying asset's value. The share price of PB Fintech on the NSE crashed 36 per cent or ₹679.10 to ₹1,207.20 (₹1,886.30). Put options of strike between 1120 and 1700 were active; of them, the 1400, 1300 and 1200 strikes were the most active as the stock crashed vertically after the initial 20 per cent circuit filter was removed.

| Whopping profits |              |           |             |            |
|------------------|--------------|-----------|-------------|------------|
| Put option       | Pr close (₹) | Close (₹) | Change (%)  | Change (₹) |
| 1500             | 0.30         | 279.5     | 93,066.67   | 279.20     |
| 1400             | 0.50         | 182.2     | 36,340.00   | 181.70     |
| 1300             | 0.05         | 100.0     | 1,99,900.00 | 99.95      |

The 1500-strike of PB Fintech fell from ₹4 on August 24 to ₹0.3 on Wednesday. However, on Thursday, the premium jumped to ₹279.95. Premiums of other put options too jumped, since many of them are deep out-of-the-money, not much interest were seen during the last few days.

**OPTION CONTRAST**  
Only the 1,500-strike was

active among deep OTM put options. On the contrary, those who had bought call options of PB Fintech would have seen their value evaporating, as the premium nosedived. The premium of 1800-call slipped from ₹92.65. Proposed caps on commissions, tighter expense-management limits and greater transparency could pressure new-business

growth and margins, while the restriction on loan-linked insurance bundling may affect distribution volumes, said Vinit Bolinjkar, Head of Research, Ventura. "PB Fintech and other broker-led platforms appear most vulnerable because their earnings are directly linked to commissions and take rates. LIC and SBI Life may be relatively better placed due to their stronger agency networks and lower distribution-cost intensity. However, the proposals remain at the consultation stage, with stakeholder comments invited until October 25, and final rules could be modified before implementation," he added.

## After 13 years, HSBC plans to return as stock broker in India

Reuters  
Mumbai

HSBC is re-entering India's equity broking business after an absence of more than a decade, seeking to capitalise on a robust pipeline of share sales and rising demand from wealthy clients for equity market products, two people with direct knowledge of the matter said. The move marks a reversal of HSBC's decision to exit the domestic retail brokerage and depository business in 2013 and underscores the growing importance of India's capital markets and wealth management industry to global banks. The London-headquartered bank has begun the process of re-building its equities platform in India and is hiring senior executives for cash equities and institutional broking roles, the people said. "Looking at the phone penetration and everybody having direct capital market



access, the idea is to have digital capabilities, and getting into the retail brokerage business is an important element there," one of the people said. The person added that interest among Indian customers for trading in international markets has also grown since the establishment of India's tax-neutral hub, GIFT City. HSBC is likely to launch retail broking services over the next few months, the second person said. The bank already holds a broking licence through HSBC Invest Direct Securities (India) Private Ltd, which it plans to use to revive the business. The people declined to be

identified because the discussions are private. HSBC did not immediately respond to a Reuters request. **GROWING INTEREST** HSBC — now India's largest foreign bank by balance sheet — is one of the few foreign banks that still has a sizeable consumer business and is pushing for a greater presence among affluent and wealthy customers. Peers such as Citibank, Standard Chartered and Deutsche Bank have chosen to focus mainly on serving large institutions. HSBC's re-entry into the broking business comes as India's equity markets continue to attract record participation from retail investors and a strong pipeline of initial public offerings. Several large IPOs are expected to come to market over the coming quarters, prompting global and local financial firms to expand their capital markets and broking capabilities.

## SRIT India to raise ₹218 cr via mainboard IPO

Our Bureau  
Mumbai

SRIT India, a leading Information Technology and ITES company, plans to raise ₹218 crore through an initial public offering on the mainboard. The issue, which opens on Monday, has been priced at ₹123-130 per share. The net proceeds will be used to fund capital expenditure towards modernisation of existing product development, working capital requirements, achieving inorganic growth and general corporate purposes. Nambiar Raghavan Madhusoodan, MD & CEO, SRIT India, said the company has built capabilities around designing, implementing and operating mission-critical digital platforms across e-governance, telecommunications and broadband and healthcare.

## Morgan Stanley rushes to check fallout after deal list leak

Bloomberg

Morgan Stanley raced to contain the damage from a leaked deal list as clients sought explanations and at least two regulators began assessing the potential fallout. The leak has gripped Asia's investment banking industry this week after one of Morgan Stanley's top bankers accidentally sent an email to some clients containing a list of more than 100 deals the Wall Street firm was working on and monitoring. Morgan Stanley held urgent meetings with some private equity firms to apologise and assure executives that the bank would work to mitigate the fallout, people familiar with the matter said, asking not to be named discussing private information. Regulators in China and India have started assessing the incident, though it's unclear if that will lead to any

action, according to people familiar with the matter. **DEAL ROSTER** The roster included candidates for initial public offerings spanning China, South Korea and India, according to a copy seen by Bloomberg News and verified by people familiar with the matter. The list — which focused primarily on Asia, alongside Europe, West Asia, and Africa — also named PE and pension funds backing the companies, as well as stalled projects. Some rivals seized on the opportunity to potentially gain ground as the document was circulated among competitors. Several bankers at rival firms said they would use the list to target deals and court potential clients. Others said most of the deals were already known and came as little surprise. Traders and investors were also monitoring potential block trades mentioned in the list.

## BROKER'S CALL.

Systematicx

**DODLA DAIRY (BUY)**  
Target: ₹1,295  
CMP: ₹1,046  
Dodla Dairy's (DODLA) management issued an upbeat business outlook at their recent non-deal roadshow in Singapore hosted by Systematicx. Management reaffirmed revenue growth guidance of 15 per cent over the medium term, expecting sales' salience of value-added products (VAP) to go to 40 per cent (from current 30 per cent). This would translate into incremental revenue/volume accretion of ₹2,800 crore/15 LLPD in the next 2-3 years (FY26: ₹4,120 crore/20 LLPD), driven by processing volume additions at Maharashtra greenfield plant of 10 LLPD, Bihar and Jharkhand (Osam) of 3 LLPD and Uganda greenfield plant of another 1.5-2 LLPD. With the Maharashtra plant, Dodla plans to sell 1-2 LLPD locally with the rest serving north Karnataka and Telangana. The Uganda greenfield enables expansion in fresh milk (vs legacy presence in long-life milk and yogurt), and should be commissioned by FY29. We expect stable India/robust Africa growth (FY26-FY29E sales CAGR of 12/22 per cent), supported by sustained high VAP growth of 20 per cent, incremental sales from capacity expansions and addition of Osam. We keep our FY27E-FY29E estimates unchanged, building FY26-FY29E revenue/PAT CAGR of 13/24 per cent. We maintain Buy rating on the stock, valuing it at P/E of 24x (broadly in-line with its current one-year forward multiple) June-2028E EPS to arrive at an unchanged TP of ₹1,295.

Ventura Securities

**SAMMAAN CAPITAL (BUY)**  
Target: ₹377.7  
CMP: ₹140.7  
Sammaan Capital's history (formerly Indiabulls Housing Finance) reflects a pattern of growth being interrupted by risk, not opportunity. The company built scale aggressively through wholesale and developer lending in its growth years. However rising asset-quality stress and funding-access challenges through FY20-24 forced a prolonged period of balance-sheet repair, reflected in deeply negative profitability (-10.9 per cent ROA/-35.6 per cent ROE) in the base year, alongside an elevated GNPA stock requiring ₹6,499 crore exceptional impairment to clean up the book. The turning point came with IHC's strategic intervention: a two-tranche ₹8,850 crore capital infusion securing a 43.5 per cent controlling stake, which triggered AA+ rating upgrades from Crisil, CARE, and ICRA, and unlocked access to lower-cost borrowings. Sammaan Capital has moved past its distressed phase into what we view as an early-stage re-rating opportunity, where strengthening profitability, IHC-led capital and governance support and improving asset quality together underpin the investment case. We initiate coverage with a BUY rating and a price target of ₹377.7 (2.0x FY29E P/ABV) over the next 24 months. **Key risks:** Rapid retail/MSME-LAP scale-up without matching underwriting discipline risks seasoning-led delinquencies, impacting GNPA and credit costs.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: [blmarketwatch@gmail.com](mailto:blmarketwatch@gmail.com)

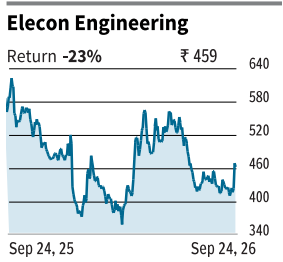
## TODAY'S PICK.

Elecon Engineering Company (₹459.40): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu  
bl. research bureau

The stock of Elecon Engineering Company has been charting a sideways trend since August. It was largely oscillating within ₹405 and ₹455.

On Wednesday, the scrip broke out of the resistance at ₹455, a notable indication that the stock might be turning the broader trend positive. Although there is a resistance at ₹575, we expect the stock to surpass this level. Nevertheless, there could be a pause in the uptrend or a minor price correction on the back of ₹575. An eventual breakout of this barrier can lift the stock to ₹620. Buy at ₹459 and



accumulate if the price dips to ₹440. Place initial stop-loss at ₹390. When the stock touches ₹575 and ₹600, revise the stop-loss to ₹515 and ₹575 respectively. Book profits at ₹620. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

## Day trading guide

23095      » Nifty 50 Futures

| S1    | S2    | R1    | R2    | COMMENT                                                         |
|-------|-------|-------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 23000 | 22800 | 23225 | 23350 | Sell the contract on a rise to 23200; place stop-loss at 23350. |

₹729      » HDFC Bank

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2  | COMMENT                                                        |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 722 | 712 | 735 | 750 | Sell the stock if it falls below 722; stop-loss can be at 730. |

₹1009      » Infosys

| S1   | S2  | R1   | R2   | COMMENT                                                        |
|------|-----|------|------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1000 | 980 | 1020 | 1030 | Short the scrip with stop-loss at 1032 if price rises to 1020. |

₹267      » ITC

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2  | COMMENT                                                      |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 265 | 262 | 270 | 276 | Stock shows positive signs; go long with a stop-loss at 260. |

₹237      » ONGC

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2  | COMMENT                                           |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|---------------------------------------------------|
| 234 | 232 | 238 | 242 | The intraday outlook appears uncertain; stay out. |

₹1219      » Reliance Ind.

| S1   | S2   | R1   | R2   | COMMENT                                                       |
|------|------|------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1200 | 1180 | 1235 | 1250 | Sell the stock if price rises to 1235; stop-loss can be 1255. |

₹978      » SBI

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2   | COMMENT                                                        |
|-----|-----|-----|------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 970 | 960 | 985 | 1000 | Stock likely to decline; go short now with a stop-loss at 990. |

₹2077      » TCS

| S1   | S2   | R1   | R2   | COMMENT                                                      |
|------|------|------|------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2020 | 2000 | 2100 | 2130 | Outlook appears weak; sell the stock with stop-loss at 2120. |

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

## ‘Listing marks new chapter for India’s capital markets’

Our Bureau  
Mumbai

The National Stock Exchange marked a landmark moment on Thursday as its shares were listed on rival BSE, following years of regulatory and legal hurdles. The NSE Managing Director and CEO, Ashishkumar Chauhan, described the listing as a significant milestone for the institution and India's capital markets. "There is nothing else that represents the aspirations of India's future than NSE. What is good for India is good for NSE," Chauhan said at the listing ceremony. He said organisations such as NSE are created only once in a generation and highlighted the exchange's role in transforming the country's capital markets. "Markets for capital are basically markets of trust," Chauhan said after 35

years in the industry, his role at NSE was the "biggest honour and privilege" of his life. He also thanked the SEBI, the government and other stakeholders for supporting the exchange's listing. "We are now a 36 lakh investor family from 2 lakh before listing," he said. Srinivas Injeti, Chairperson, NSE, said the exchange's public listing marked a new chapter in its journey, while its responsibilities remained unchanged. He said the exchange was established with the mandate of transforming India's capital markets and had delivered on that objective. Sundararaman Ramamurthy, CEO, BSE described NSE's listing as a "dream come true" and said it was particularly significant for him given his two decades at NSE. He called it a "great honour" for BSE to host the listing ceremony of its rival.

## SEBI announces fourth settlement scheme for illiquid stock options

five contracts and ₹2.88 lakh for six to 50 contracts. For 51 contracts and above, the amount will be ₹7.20 lakh plus ₹14,400 per contract. For example, the settlement amount for 51 contracts will be ₹14.544 lakh.

**SETTLEMENT HISTORY** SEBI said three earlier settlement schemes for such matters were introduced in 2020, 2022 and 2024, under which a large number of concerned entities settled proceedings. The latest scheme was approved by the competent authority following recommendations of the High

Power Advisory Committee and was placed before the Board for information. The modalities for making applications will be announced separately. SEBI which had conducted a probe between April 1, 2014, and March 31, 2015, found that a set of entities were repeatedly incurring significant losses by executing reversal trades in the Stock Options segment of BSE, and another set of entities were repeatedly making significant profits by becoming their counterparties in orchestrated trades with a common objective of intended execution of the non-genuine trades.

| Nifty 50 Movers             |          |        |       |       | ▼ 383.70 pts. |
|-----------------------------|----------|--------|-------|-------|---------------|
|                             | Close(₹) | Pts    | PE    | WN(%) |               |
| Cipla                       | 1399.00  | 1.97   | 33.68 | 0.75  |               |
| ONGC                        | 239.00   | 1.78   | 6.71  | 0.88  |               |
| NTPC                        | 526.60   | 0.62   | 11.18 | 1.47  |               |
| SBI Life                    | 1755.00  | -0.49  | 67.69 | 0.75  |               |
| TCS                         | 2087.00  | -0.58  | 15.09 | 2.02  |               |
| Wipro                       | 163.64   | -0.75  | 12.20 | 0.42  |               |
| TataConsumerProduct         | 986.30   | -1.14  | 59.44 | 0.61  |               |
| Coal India                  | 422.00   | -1.33  | 8.34  | 0.96  |               |
| Dr Reddys Lab               | 1200.40  | -1.44  | 31.47 | 0.69  |               |
| Graissim Ind                | 3166.50  | -1.81  | 18.94 | 1.13  |               |
| Tech Mahindra               | 1543.00  | -1.94  | 29.29 | 0.59  |               |
| Max Healthcare              | 1046.00  | -2.26  | 69.85 | 0.74  |               |
| Tata Motors PV              | 295.00   | -2.51  | 0.00  | 0.58  |               |
| UltraTech Cement            | 11056.00 | -2.56  | 38.01 | 1.24  |               |
| HCL Tech                    | 1243.60  | -3.02  | 19.36 | 1.24  |               |
| Bharat Elec                 | 592.00   | -3.17  | 46.61 | 1.33  |               |
| Hind Unilever               | 1933.50  | -3.20  | 43.29 | 1.63  |               |
| Sun Pharma                  | 1849.90  | -3.49  | 36.63 | 1.86  |               |
| Adani Ports                 | 1785.30  | -3.55  | 31.35 | 1.25  |               |
| Jio Financial Services Ltd. | 227.20   | -3.55  | 72.60 | 0.71  |               |
| PowerGrid Corp              | 266.40   | -3.76  | 15.59 | 1.14  |               |
| Eicher Motors               | 7338.50  | -3.96  | 34.90 | 0.96  |               |
| Apollo Hosp                 | 8888.50  | -4.04  | 58.49 | 0.92  |               |
| ITC                         | 4832.50  | -4.29  | 74.48 | 1.89  |               |
| Titan                       | 268.00   | -4.53  | 16.64 | 2.45  |               |
| Infosys                     | 1014.50  | -4.60  | 13.57 | 3.37  |               |
| Bajaj Auto                  | 11208.00 | -4.65  | 27.12 | 1.18  |               |
| JSW Steel                   | 1273.20  | -5.04  | 11.12 | 1.13  |               |
| Tata Steel                  | 188.02   | -5.06  | 20.84 | 1.47  |               |
| Trent Ltd.                  | 2780.00  | -5.38  | 79.34 | 0.85  |               |
| NestleIndia                 | 1351.00  | -5.67  | 68.36 | 0.92  |               |
| Adani Enter                 | 2900.00  | -5.88  | 50.22 | 0.79  |               |
| Asian Paints                | 2392.70  | -6.16  | 47.45 | 1.03  |               |
| Shriram Finance Ltd.        | 990.00   | -6.37  | 20.58 | 1.31  |               |
| Maruti Suzuki               | 11590.00 | -6.84  | 26.30 | 1.48  |               |
| Int'l Shipwkr               | 4899.50  | -6.84  | 6.84  | 1.05  |               |
| Hindalco                    | 982.00   | -6.90  | 13.46 | 1.35  |               |
| HDFC Life                   | 526.90   | -8.13  | 57.57 | 0.54  |               |
| ICICI Bank                  | 1334.50  | -8.61  | 16.02 | 9.06  |               |
| M&M                         | 2982.70  | -10.20 | 18.32 | 2.52  |               |
| Bajaj Finserv               | 1762.30  | -10.65 | 13.67 | 0.97  |               |
| Eternal Ltd.                | 335.50   | -14.25 | 74.74 | 2.30  |               |
| Kotak Bank                  | 405.00   | -13.27 | 19.85 | 2.73  |               |
| State Bank                  | 978.50   | -14.09 | 10.07 | 3.83  |               |
| L&T                         | 3858.40  | -18.29 | 27.05 | 4.28  |               |
| Bharti Airtel               | 1795.80  | -24.85 | 30.05 | 5.17  |               |
| HDFC Bank                   | 728.90   | -27.94 | 13.60 | 10.58 |               |
| Axis Bank                   | 1186.50  | -35.58 | 13.21 | 3.23  |               |
| Bajaj Finance               | 982.00   | -35.94 | 29.61 | 2.49  |               |
| Reliance Ind                | 1219.20  | -42.52 | 18.71 | 7.80  |               |

Pts: Impact on index movement

| Nifty Next 50 Movers        |          |         |        |       | ▼ 1,080.95 pts. |
|-----------------------------|----------|---------|--------|-------|-----------------|
|                             | Close(₹) | Pts     | PE     | WN(%) |                 |
| ZydusLifesciences           | 1180.30  | 7.42    | 25.86  | 1.20  |                 |
| Gail (India)                | 173.85   | 7.05    | 11.58  | 1.91  |                 |
| Abb India                   | 7129.00  | 1.37    | 97.14  | 1.52  |                 |
| Siemens Energy India        | 3215.40  | 0.26    | 76.95  | 1.16  |                 |
| Canara Bank                 | 125.90   | -0.98   | 5.76   | 1.72  |                 |
| Mazagon Dock                | 2202.00  | -2.10   | 31.12  | 0.68  |                 |
| Union Bank                  | 179.45   | -3.09   | 6.64   | 1.41  |                 |
| Macrotech Developers        | 1158.00  | -3.63   | 28.02  | 1.31  |                 |
| Bosch                       | 47750.00 | -5.17   | 59.59  | 1.69  |                 |
| Godrej Consumer             | 975.00   | -5.55   | 46.79  | 1.43  |                 |
| Shree Cement                | 22350.00 | -5.83   | 49.29  | 1.22  |                 |
| Indian Railway Finance Corp | 79.86    | -6.66   | 14.51  | 0.65  |                 |
| Divis Lab                   | 9602.00  | -8.13   | 87.15  | 4.97  |                 |
| DIF                         | 670.40   | -8.58   | 37.33  | 1.73  |                 |
| MuthootFin                  | 2825.30  | -9.72   | 9.90   | 1.25  |                 |
| Siemens                     | 3841.80  | -11.35  | 94.17  | 1.38  |                 |
| Hindus Zinc                 | 587.15   | -16.60  | 14.54  | 1.15  |                 |
| Britannia Ind               | 4895.00  | -11.64  | 45.17  | 2.35  |                 |
| Rural Elec                  | 304.55   | -11.80  | 5.00   | 1.57  |                 |
| Punjab Natl Bank            | 117.12   | -11.81  | 6.08   | 1.64  |                 |
| Limnintreed                 | 4038.00  | -12.69  | 23.05  | 1.53  |                 |
| Bank Of Orissa              | 234.30   | -13.86  | 6.59   | 1.77  |                 |
| Humdini India               | 2066.00  | -14.25  | 33.82  | 1.20  |                 |
| Chunjab Motors Ltd.         | 4973.00  | -14.52  | 58.24  | 2.73  |                 |
| United Spirits              | 1423.30  | -15.19  | 61.37  | 1.71  |                 |
| Ambuja Cements              | 309.15   | -15.67  | 10.37  | 1.07  |                 |
| Cg Power & Ind Sol          | 86.76    | -16.54  | 112.79 | 24.48 |                 |
| Vedanta                     | 267.50   | -17.25  | 6.27   | 1.85  |                 |
| Solar Industries            | 19480.00 | -17.70  | 85.97  | 1.93  |                 |
| Jindal Steel                | 1157.80  | -18.84  | 43.80  | 2.45  |                 |
| Varun Beverages             | 43.25    | -19.47  | 42.78  | 2.40  |                 |
| Tata Capital                | 336.25   | -20.19  | 26.06  | 0.69  |                 |
| Adani Engineering           | 1280.10  | -20.27  | 96.25  | 1.75  |                 |
| Adani Power                 | 1136.27  | -20.41  | 5.90   | 1.27  |                 |
| AvenueSuper                 | 3787.50  | -22.15  | 80.80  | 2.48  |                 |
| Torrent Pharma              | 4928.25  | -24.09  | 86.95  | 2.94  |                 |
| Samarvad&DentorsInternatml  | 162.50   | -24.39  | 33.10  | 2.62  |                 |
| Tata Power                  | 363.45   | -26.50  | 22.10  | 2.47  |                 |
| Power Finance               | 339.35   | -28.14  | 3.33   | 2.01  |                 |
| Tcs Mtor Corp               | 4091.00  | -30.04  | 53.97  | 3.91  |                 |
| Adani Telecommunications    | 477.00   | -34.07  | 24.59  | 3.69  |                 |
| Adani Energy Solutions      | 13405.75 | -37.70  | 52.11  | 2.79  |                 |
| Adani Hotels Co             | 72.80    | -38.02  | 44.93  | 2.61  |                 |
| Hdfc Amc                    | 2380.30  | -40.29  | 34.61  | 1.98  |                 |
| Bpcl                        | 307.10   | -50.95  | 7.78   | 2.53  |                 |
| Pidilint                    | 1522.00  | -59.52  | 57.88  | 1.92  |                 |
| Adani Power                 | 199.48   | -64.15  | 26.47  | 3.37  |                 |
| Bajaj Holdings              | 10917.00 | -66.94  | 135.1  | 1.92  |                 |
| Tata Motors                 | 437.15   | -79.21  | 38.45  | 3.74  |                 |
| Cholamandlams&Fin           | 166.70   | -116.04 | 24.93  | 2.96  |                 |

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

UltraTech Cement adds 4.6 mtpa fresh capacity



**Mumbai:** UltraTech Cement, an Aditya Birla Group company, has commissioned 4.6 mtpa of cement capacity in Andhra Pradesh, Jharkhand and Rajasthan. Consequent to fresh capacity addition, its total domestic grey cement manufacturing capacity now stands augmented to 204.7 mtpa. OUR BUREAU

GalaxEye to get ₹63 crore under RDI fund

**New Delhi:** The Department of Space's Technology Development Board (TDB) is set to provide financial support of more than ₹63 crore to Bengaluru-based GalaxEye for developing next-generation multisensor satellite technology. TDB and GalaxEye signed an agreement related to the financial support under the Research Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund, officials said on Thursday. **PH**

Godrej family members buy 1% stake in group co

**New Delhi:** Four members of the Godrej family, on Thursday, bought a 1 per cent stake in FMCG major Godrej Consumer Products for over ₹900 crore, buying the shares from two promoter group entities through separate block deals. Together, they purchased 1,02,30,000 shares, representing a 0.99 per cent stake in Mumbai-based Godrej Consumer Products, according to data on the BSE. The shares were bought at an average price of ₹880. **PH**

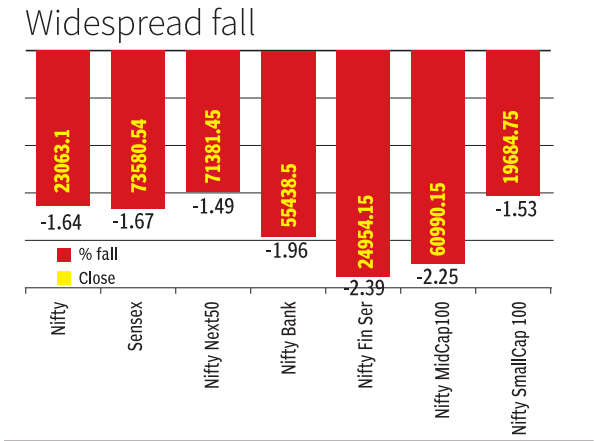
# US yield shock, oil surge hammer equities; Nifty hits lowest since April 7

**BROAD SELLING.** Sensex tumbled 1,248 points to end at 73,581, while the Nifty 50 fell 384 points to 23,063

Our Bureau  
Mumbai

The growing global uncertainty and a sharp spike in US bond yields triggered a broad-based sell-off in equity markets, dragging BSE Sensex to its lowest levels in three months. The BSE Sensex tumbled 1,248 points to close at 73,581, while the Nifty 50 shed 384 points to end at 23,063 on Thursday. The Nifty 50 slipped to its lowest level in 118 trading sessions, touching levels last seen on April 7, while the Sensex fell to a 76-session low, revisiting levels seen on June 11.

**IN RED ALL ACROSS**  
Selling pressure was wide-



spread, with all major Nifty sectoral indices ending in the red. The broader Nifty Smallcap 100 and Nifty Midcap 100 indices declined 1.53 per cent and 2.08 per cent, respectively.

**TREASURY YIELDS**  
The rupee remained under pressure, weakening by 22 paise to close at 95.96 against the US dollar, as geopolitical tensions fuelled a sharp rise in crude oil prices and

pushed US Treasury yields and the greenback higher. According to Vaibhav Chugh, Chief Executive Officer of Abakkus Mutual Fund, the sharp decline in domestic equities was driven by US 10-year Treasury yields reaching their highest level in nearly two decades, coupled with hawkish commentary from Federal Reserve officials signalling the possibility of further rate hikes. The yield on the US 10-year Treasury climbed above 5.10 per cent, a level last seen in 2007, while Brent crude prices surged past the \$102-106 per barrel range.

**FII FLOWS**  
“In the short term, foreign institutional investor (FII) flows could remain sensitive

to rising US yields, which offer relatively higher risk-free returns,” Chugh said. Back home, a consultation paper issued by the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India proposing tighter caps on distribution payouts also triggered sharp selling in select stocks. “Although valuations in India have moderated from their long-term averages, they have not yet become attractive enough to trigger a strong return of foreign investors,” said Chugh. Corporate earnings have remained resilient, he pointed out, and if that trend continues over the next few quarters, “FIIs are likely to gain the confidence needed to increase allocations to India,” he added.

## SEBI okays new settlement framework

Our Bureau  
Mumbai

SEBI on Thursday approved a new settlement framework that will replace the 2018 regulations, introducing a formula-based system for settlement amounts, separate treatment of wrongful gains and wider access to settlement. The new framework will come into force 30 days from the date of notification. As per the new formula, the base amount will be linked to the minimum penalty prescribed for the violation under securities laws, with multipliers based on the type of applicant. The formula will then take into account the stage of proceedings, regulatory action,

gravity of the default, and aggravating and mitigating factors. Wrongful gains, loss avoided or loss caused to investors will not be included in the base amount. Where quantified, these amounts will instead be disgorged separately, removing what SEBI described as double counting in the computation of settlement terms. **FAST-TRACK ROUTE** Under the new rules, SEBI can issue a settlement notice before issuing a show-cause notice (SCN), giving an entity 60 days to apply for settlement. The deadline for applying for settlement after an SCN will also rise to 90 days from 60 days. A fast-track route will be

**Under the new rules, SEBI can issue a settlement notice before issuing a show-cause notice, giving an entity 60 days to apply for settlement**

lations, subject to specified conditions and an additional 20 per cent settlement amount. Earlier rejected applications can also be considered at the appellate stage where the grounds for rejection no longer apply. SEBI will also allow settlement of cases involving misrepresentation of financial statements or diversion or siphoning of funds, subject to appropriate remedial and regulatory terms, including disclosures and bringing back diverted funds. For adjudication proceedings, remedial and regulatory terms will ordinarily not be imposed, although quantified wrongful gains or investor losses will be disgorged and appropriate disclosures may be required in disclosure-related cases.

Our Bureau  
Mumbai

SEBI approved a broad package of reforms covering portfolio management services, settlement proceedings, commodity derivatives, alternative investment funds, REITs, InvITs and investor accreditation, in one of the regulator's most comprehensive policy overhauls in recent years. At the centre of the reforms is a complete rewrite of the portfolio management framework through the new SEBI (Portfolio Managers) Regulations, 2026, which replace the 2020 regulations. Under the new framework, portfolio managers can invest up to 10 per cent of a client's assets under

## IRDAI's distribution reforms, a tightrope walk for insurers and intermediaries

G Naga Sridhar  
Hyderabad

The new distribution norms, proposed by the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) on Wednesday, may result in a tightrope walk for insurers and intermediaries. The comprehensive framework of reforms covers insurance distribution, its structure, expenses, commissions, market conduct, transparency and leveraging digital infrastructure. “The proposals such as lower limits on expenses management and regulating commissions are expected to change business and operational dynamics for insurers and pose new challenges,” the MD and CEO of a general insurance company told *businessline* on Thursday. Alok Rungta, MD and



**PARADIGM SHIFT.** The reforms can encourage brokers to move from volume-led distribution to value-led advisory **ISTOCK.COM**

CEO, Generali Central Life Insurance, said his company was currently evaluating the proposals to understand their implications for the business and the broader distribution ecosystem. There are areas where insurers would seek further clarity as the consultation progresses. “At the heart of our assessment will be how the pro-

posed framework balances distribution efficiency with the need for quality advice, long-term customer servicing and wider insurance penetration,” he said. “After arriving at a comprehensive view, we will work together to co-create a calibrated action plan and engagement approach,” Rungta added.

**KEY CHANGE**  
According to Amit Goel, Director, Equirus Raghnaill Insurance Broking, IRDAI's proposed reforms would mark an important shift in insurance distribution — from simply chasing premium growth to focusing on quality, efficiency and customer value. “For insurers and intermediaries, the proposed EoM glide path and effort-based commission structures should push the industry to look harder at acquisition costs, productivity, renewal quality and servicing efficiency,” Goel said. The reforms can, therefore, encourage brokers to move from volume-led distribution to value-led advisory. “For customers, greater transparency and accountability should improve suitability and trust,” he added.

## Waaree Group enters specialty gases market

Our Bureau  
Ahmedabad

Waaree Clean Energy Solutions (WCES), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Mumbai-based Waaree Energies, announced its entry into the specialty gases market by proposing to set up a plant at GIDC Saykha in Dahej, Gujarat, to supply ultra-high-purity (UHP) gases and chemicals to semiconductor and solar cell manufacturers. The new pan-India business will target semiconductor fabs, OSAT and ATMP facilities, advanced electronics manufacturers and solar cell production lines, as India seeks to build domestic capacity across the semiconductor and electronics manufacturing ecosystem, the company stated in an official release on Thursday. WCES plans to develop the specialty gases business in phases. The initial plans



include multi-purpose warehousing and storage infrastructure, a dedicated unit for purification of UHP ammonia and a phosphine-hydrogen (PH<sub>3</sub>/H<sub>2</sub>) mixing plant. The company also plans to add UHP oxygen, while UHP hydrogen is already commercially available. The company plans to offer a broader portfolio of high-purity gases and chemicals, including silane, ammonia, nitrous oxide, phosphine mixtures, boron trichloride (BCl<sub>3</sub>), trimethyl aluminium, diborane, germane/hydrogen mixtures, HBr, SF<sub>6</sub>, nitric oxide, fluor-

**The business will target semiconductor fabs, OSAT and ATMP facilities, advanced electronics manufacturers and solar cell production lines**

inated gases and calibration gases. WCES will also provide customised gas and chemical supply systems and nitrogen plants. Its proposed Total Gas & Chemical Management System will cover storage, delivery, safety monitoring and inventory management. **NATURAL EXTENSION** “Semiconductor and solar cell manufacturing cannot scale in India without a reliable, high-purity gas and

chemical supply chain alongside it,” Anuj Sharma, CEO of WCES, stated. “This is a natural extension of our deep-tech manufacturing and clean energy expertise,” he added. The company said high-purity process gases and chemicals are still largely imported and that building domestic supply would help address a critical requirement for India's semiconductor and solar manufacturing ambitions. *businessline* had, in April, 2026 reported on Waaree's plans for a semiconductor forum, as the company looked to participate in India's expanding semiconductor and electronics manufacturing value chain. The specialty gases business will give Waaree a presence in an important upstream segment of the semiconductor manufacturing supply chain, rather than semiconductor chip fabrication itself.

# ‘Bigger concern is future availability of manganese ore for steel companies’

bl.interview

Suresh P Iyengar  
Mumbai

Steel industry has been on a major expansion spree and targets to enhance capacity to 300 million tonne per annum (mtpa) by 2030 from the current 222 mtpa. Though ample iron ore and coal reserves are available in India, the industry has to depend on imports for ferro alloys, especially that of manganese. India imports about 60-65 per cent of its manganese ore requirement from South Africa, Gabon and Australia. Manganese is an essential additive in steel-making that removes impurities and significantly improves strength, toughness and wear resistance. Its usage will increase further as steel companies focus on improving the quality, according to Manish

Sarda, Deputy MD, Sarda Metals & Ferro Alloys. Edited excerpts:

**What are the key challenges facing the mining industry?**  
One of the key issues is the high premium being quoted in mining auctions. The government needs to re-look at the system because the highest premium does not necessarily mean that the mine will actually come into production. If the premium makes the mine unviable, it can eventually lead to surrender of the mine. We have seen examples of manganese mines in Odisha being awarded at premiums of about 140 per cent, which is clearly difficult to sustain economically. Mining also has to be carried out in a systematic and responsible manner, with adequate safeguards for ecology and the environment. If mining is done properly at a viable premium while main-

taining ecological balance, there should not be an issue. **Should the government tighten the qualification criteria for companies bidding for mines?**  
The government could look more closely at the actual users and their qualifications. Companies are competing aggressively for resources because they want raw material security, so it is a difficult situation to manage. One possible approach is a public-private partnership model, where mining actually starts and the pricing of ore and profitability-sharing mechanism are determined using international ore indices. That would provide transparency and give companies greater raw material security instead of forcing them to depend entirely on imports. **Is manganese ore going to become a major**

We need to explore more extensively and understand where our resource base lies, and then bring those resources into production **MANISH SARDA**  
Deputy MD, Sarda Metals & Ferro Alloys **constraint as steel capacity expands?**  
The country has adequate capacity to produce manganese alloys and is meeting domestic requirements before exporting. Manganese ore imports, however, are taking place on a significant scale, while imports of manganese alloys are restricted. The bigger concern is future availability of ore. If major mining countries such as South Africa, Ghana, Gabon



and Australia increasingly focus on developing their own downstream value-addition, it could become a significant challenge for the Indian manganese alloy industry. We need to develop our own mineral resource base through greater exploration. Raw material resource security has become strategically important, particularly as countries around the world increasingly seek to secure

resources and add value within their own economies. **How important is exploration for India's mineral security?**  
It is extremely important. This is a futuristic concern because many countries are increasingly securing their own raw materials and promoting value-addition domestically. India has not undertaken enough deep exploration for high-grade mineral ores such as manganese and chrome. These resources are also concentrated in certain States. We, therefore, need to explore more extensively and understand where our resource base lies, and then bring those resources into production. The government has the capability and institutional infrastructure to undertake exploration. It should explore deposits to a stage where they become viable and commercially saleable.

Currently, we are seeing either very low premiums and limited interest or very high premiums for proven resources. **What is the raw material challenge for the steel industry?**  
India has substantial iron ore and coal resources. What is important is upgrading low-grade resources to make them commercially useful, and that is already happening on a significant scale. Costs could rise to some extent because of carbon-related requirements and stricter mining regulations, which are necessary. However, if the industry scales up, costs can eventually come down. **What steps you are taking to meet CBAM norms to tap EU?**  
Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) will be a challenge during the transition. It will take some time

for the industry to adapt, but it is a process that companies will have to go through. Those that evolve faster and adapt to the new requirements will be in a better position. We are investing in solar and hydropower and are trying to reduce our carbon footprint through waste-heat recovery and utilisation of waste gases. We have recently taken up a ₹300-crore expansion plan at our Vizag plant for waste-heat recovery and utilisation of waste. We hope to gradually move through this process and make our operations as green as possible. We are looking at solar and hydropower projects in the north-eastern States and Chhattisgarh. We currently have two or three projects under consideration. Some of these investments are still at the discussion stage, and we are continuously evaluating the available opportunities.

QUICKLY.

YouTube Shopping expands India network



**New Delhi:** Video streaming platform YouTube on Thursday announced the expansion of its shopping affiliate programme in India, partnering with major e-commerce platforms, including Amazon, AJO, Meesho, Snapdeal, and Tata CLiQ. The new tie-ups build upon YouTube's existing affiliate partnerships with Flipkart, Myntra, Nykaa, Purple, Shopsy, and Tira, creating a unified digital catalogue spanning value marketplaces, fashion, and beauty retail, the company said. The expansion comes amid surging economic returns for local creators, the company said.

Radisson expects to double India headcount by 2030

**New Delhi:** Hospitality major Radisson Hotel Group expects to double its headcount in India by 2030 from about 19,000 at present and is targeting to increase the country's contribution to 20 per cent of its global revenues in the next five years from about 15-16 per cent currently, its top executives said on Thursday. In an interview to PTI, Radisson Hotel Group Global President & Chief Operating Officer (COO) Chema Basterrechea and Nikhil Sharma, Managing Director & COO - South Asia, shared its blueprint for growth in India, with the hospitality player exploring branded residences and potential announcements expected by 2027 once legal frameworks regarding RERA (Real Estate Regulatory Authority) are understood.

# Consumer durables market set to hit ₹3.25 lakh cr by 2030: BCG-CII

**BUYING SPREE.** 8-10% annual growth could add ₹40,000-50,000 crore in domestic value, says report

**Meenakshi Verma Ambwani**  
New Delhi

India's consumer durables sector is expected to grow at 8-10 per cent annually through 2030 to reach ₹3-3.25 lakh crore, outpacing other major consumer durables market, according to a joint report by Boston Consulting Group (BCG) and the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII). The report indicated that this could create an incremental ₹40,000-50,000 crore opportunity for domestic value addition across materials and conversion.

The industry's growth is expected to be led by room air-conditioner segment projected to grow at 10-12 per cent CAGR, followed by LED TVs segment expected to grow at 8-10 per cent during this period.

Low household penetration, rising affluence, nuclearisation of families, easy financing and wider distribution will be fuelling the growth of the sector. At the same time, premiumisa-

India durables growth to outpace all major markets...

Consumer durables market size and growth, 2019-30F (\$ billion)

| Market  | 2019 | 2025 | 2030F   | CAGR %             |                     |
|---------|------|------|---------|--------------------|---------------------|
|         |      |      |         | Historic (2019-25) | Forecast (2025-30F) |
| China   | 135  | 151  | 155-160 | 2                  | 1-2                 |
| US      | 123  | 148  | 185-190 | 3                  | 4-6                 |
| Germany | 26   | 32   | 34-36   | 4                  | 1-3                 |
| Japan   | 29   | 31   | 34-36   | 1                  | 1-3                 |
| UK      | 17   | 23   | 27-29   | 5                  | 3-5                 |
| India   | 14   | 23   | 30-35   | 9                  | 8-10                |
| Global  | 549  | 709  | 900-950 | 4                  | 5-7                 |

Source: Home Grown, World Ready

tion and replacement demand will add another layer of growth, it added.

### MAIN BARRIERS

"At the current trajectory of localisation, a significant share of this opportunity could still be met through imports by 2030. Closing this gap will require deeper localisation of critical components, where technology access and scale economics remain key barriers," the report said. Current bill-of-materials (BOM) localisa-

tion ranges from 25-70 per cent across major categories, with TVs and air conditioners at the lower end and refrigerators and washing machines at the higher end. But critical components such as TV display panels.

India imports durable components about ₹20,000 crore of annually, with localisation ranging from 40-70 per cent across major categories, as per estimates of the report.

For instance, the Indian TV market is set to reach

## Amazon bets \$3 billion on India's quick commerce business

Reuters

New Delhi/San Francisco

US e-commerce retailer Amazon will invest \$3 billion to expand its India quick commerce business by 2030, two sources said, its biggest bet yet on a sector where rivals have raced ahead by popularising deliveries within minutes.

The instant deliveries sector, dubbed "quick com-

merce", has become a rapidly growing force and reshaped how urban Indians shop for everything from milk and chocolates to iPhones and electronics, which were once only bought from retail stores or major e-commerce websites where deliveries took time.

Walmart's Flipkart and Amazon, which dominate India's e-commerce space, are late entrants in quick commerce. The \$19 billion sector

is set to more than double in size to \$41 billion by 2030, according to Datum Intelligence.

### INVESTMENT PLAN

Amazon plans to invest \$1 billion in the quick commerce sector by the end of 2027, and another \$2 billion by 2030, two people with direct knowledge of the plans said. The planned investment has not previously been reported. Amazon de-

about ₹65,000-75,000 crore by 2030 but only about 25-30 per cent of the material value add currently happens in India as a key component, which is display panel is fully imported.

"India's next chapter in consumer durables will be defined not just by the size of its domestic market, but by the depth of capabilities we build around it. Over the next five years, market growth could create an incremental ₹40,000-50,000 crore opportunity for domestic value addition. Capturing that opportunity will require a globally competitive ecosystem — with deeper component manufacturing, stronger R&D and product innovation, AI-led productivity, and the scale to serve global markets.

"The choices we make today on technology, manufacturing scale and ecosystem development will determine whether India evolves from being a large consumer market to becoming a global manufacturing and innovation hub," said Mehak Dhir, Managing Dir-

ector and Partner at Boston Consulting Group (BCG).

### KEY CATEGORIES

Deeper localisation will also need to remain commercially viable while keeping products affordable for consumers as India remains a price-sensitive market, with entry-level prices declining in real terms across key categories despite inflation.

The report also highlights that unlocking this opportunity will require coordinated action across driving localisation, scaling exports, strengthening R&D and product innovation, leveraging AI for cost and efficiency gains and a regulatory roadmap.

Abheek Singhi, Managing Director & Senior Partner, BCG, said: "The opportunity is much larger than domestic market growth alone. The next phase must be about building deeper capabilities across components, technology, product design and manufacturing, and using India's domestic scale as a springboard for global competitiveness."

clined to comment on the planned investment numbers. The retailer, however, said its quick commerce business has crossed \$1 billion in annualised gross sales over the past three months, "making it the fastest-growing e-commerce business in Amazon India's history."

A key focus of the planned investment will be adding new small neighbourhood warehouses to the current Amazon Now service net-

work from where deliveries are shipped quickly, said both sources, who declined to be identified as the plan is confidential.

"Expansion needs money," the first source said.

The other key areas of spending, the first person added, will be strengthening inventory management software at stores, deploying AI tools for demand prediction and expanding products election.

## Cheviot focuses on domestic market, develops new value-added jute products for exports

Mithun Dasgupta

Kolkata

Facing stiff challenges in the international market due to high raw jute prices, jute products maker Cheviot Company Ltd is focusing more on the domestic market and developing new and value-added products for exports to protect margins.

Raw jute prices are currently hovering around ₹13,000 a quintal, compared with a five-year average of around ₹6,000 a quintal. Amid uncertainty over raw jute availability, prices had touched ₹19,000 a quintal in early July.

### LEAN INVENTORIES

"Given the size of this year's crop, the industry expected raw jute prices to soften much more than they have. Mills today are carrying only about 15 to 17 days of inventory, against the one-and-a-half to two months of stock they typically hold," Cheviot Company Ltd's whole-time Director Utkarsh Kanoria told *businessline*.

An insufficient raw jute



**BUSINESS STRATEGY.** The company has two plants – located in Budge Budge and Falta Special Economic Zone – in West Bengal

crop last year created a difficult situation for the jute industry throughout the season. Prices began rising at the start of the jute year 2025-26, as the crop size remained depressed at around 76 lakh bales of 180 kg each, compared to approximately 75 lakh bales in 2024-25. Significantly, India's raw jute production in 2023-24 was 90 lakh bales.

Additionally, after Bangladesh abruptly announced a ban on the export of raw jute from September 2025, domestic raw jute prices experienced an abnormal escalation.

For the jute year 2026-27, crop size is estimated to be around 92-95 lakh bales, as higher remunerative prices

## Titan Engineering expects semicon to contribute 20% of sales in 5 years

Aishwarya Kumar

Bengaluru



Sridhar NP, Managing Director & CEO

Titan Engineering & Automation (TEAL), the engineering arm of Titan Company, expects semiconductors to become a significantly larger contributor to its business, with the segment potentially accounting for around 20 per cent of sales in the next four to five years, up from 5-10 per cent currently, MD & CEO Sridhar N P told *businessline*.

The company is already in discussions with OSATs, or outsourced semiconductor assembly and testing companies, as it looks to build equipment capabilities for India's emerging semiconductor manufacturing ecosystem.

"Today, if you see, if I could look at that as an industry, its contribution to our overall sales revenues is not that much, maybe 5-10 per cent actually. But going forward, we think that could touch 20 per cent of our sales," Sridhar said.

The company's semiconductor push comes as TEAL increases investments in manufacturing capabilities. Sridhar said a larger portion of the company's ongoing capital expenditure is being directed towards new capabilities, particularly in manufacturing, with semiconductor among the areas receiving increased investment.

"We are investing more now in semicon... which is for the future growth that we see there," he said.

TEAL, which reported a total income of ₹1,499 crore during FY25-26, and an EBIT of ₹287 crore during the same period, has two broad businesses — automation solutions and precision manufacturing. Automation ac-

counted for about 60 per cent of revenue, according to Sridhar.

### GLOBAL GROWTH

The company is also looking beyond its existing export markets. While Europe and Mexico will remain key international markets, TEAL is now evaluating Vietnam and expects to enter the market by early 2027.

"Our focus is on India, and our focus is also maybe going a little east. Maybe Vietnam is another market that we are looking at," Sridhar said.

He said Europe has shown signs of recovering after declining over the past two years, while India has grown significantly. TEAL has installations across European markets including the Czech Republic, Slovakia, Romania, France and Germany, besides Mexico.

Interestingly, he said TEAL's manufacturing opportunities are not primarily being driven by the China+1 trend. Instead, semiconductor and equipment opportunities are largely linked to India's own manufacturing investments, while electronics could benefit from companies seeking more resilient supply chains.

"In the equipment side, most of what we are seeing as opportunities has nothing to do with China plus one... it is all India investments, India's needs of equipment," he concluded.

## Deeptech company Optimized Group sees defence driving 50% of business in five years

Aishwarya Kumar

Bengaluru

Deeptech player Optimized Group, which builds indigenous technologies across space, defence and nuclear applications, expects defence to become its largest business over the next five years, accounting for around 50 per cent of its revenue, as products developed over the last few years move into production volumes.

Space is currently the group's largest business, followed by nuclear, with defence the third-largest segment. However, Chairman & MD Sandeep Shah expects this mix to change significantly, with space contributing about 30 per cent and

other critical technologies, including nuclear, accounting for the remaining 20 per cent over the longer term.

"Many of those products that we developed in the last few years are now getting into production volumes," Shah said, adding that the group's defence order book was already building in that direction.

### GLOBAL EXPANSION

The group is also looking to expand its international business. Exports currently account for less than 10 per cent of revenue, but Optimized expects this to rise to nearly 20 per cent within the next two years. Its defence products are currently being offered to customers in Africa and South-East Asia.



Sandeep Shah, Chairman & MD, Optimized Group

The company is already supplying fully formed electro-optical systems for observation, rather than individual sensors, to overseas markets. A key part of its expansion plans is a more than 1-lakh sq ft electronics development facility.

The facility will include a

large clean room capable of building LEO satellites weighing up to 500 kg, as well as in-house radio-frequency infrastructure for radar and counter-unmanned-system applications. The company plans to fund the facility through internal reserves and government project finance, while evaluating potential equity funding.

### IPO PLANS

Shah said the group could consider a public listing in at least two years, once it reaches a stronger scale.

The company currently remains dependent on specific components imported from France, Israel and the US, although it plans to localise some of these technologies over time.

## Greenr targets another \$30 m for climate start-ups

Amit Vijay Mohile

Mumbai

More than 300 Indian green businesses have gone through TechnoServe's Greenr Sustainability Accelerator, recording average revenue growth of 51 per cent as the programme increasingly focuses on connecting climate ventures with capital, corporate customers and routes to commercial scale.

IKEA Foundation and Visa Foundation-backed Greenr Sustainability Accelerator plans to help Indian climate and sustainability start-ups mobilise another \$30 million in equity, debt and grants after facilitating close to \$30 million over the past three years, as it seeks to move more green ventures from pilots to commercially viable businesses.

Greenr's year-long, equity-free programme provides one-on-one business advice, investor access, market linkages and environmental-impact tools. It



Ajay Menon, Senior Practice Lead for Entrepreneurship at TechnoServe India and Program Director of Greenr

has run three cohorts spanning waste, energy, agriculture, textiles, green construction, forestry, FMCG and personal care.

"The next phase is not just about mobilising more capital. The challenge for climate startups is to move beyond pilots and build commercially viable businesses that can attract institutional capital and become part of large corporate supply chains," said Ajay Menon, Senior Practice Lead for Entrepreneurship at TechnoServe India and Program

Director of Greenr. The \$30-million target will measure Greenr's ability to unlock capital. The harder test is whether India's climate ventures can turn pilots into repeat orders and sustainable revenues.

"Greenr's investment formula is very unique, comprising 70 per cent equity, 20 per cent grants, and 10 per cent debt. Waste-to-value businesses accounted for 42 per cent of the funding, while agriculture and allied ventures contributed another 24 per cent, Menon said.

### SCALED START-UPS

Among the beneficiaries is Brisil Technologies, which converts rice-husk ash into green silica used in tyres and footwear.

Greenr helped it address working-capital constraints through a distributor-led model. Brisil subsequently moved from 45 per cent to full capacity utilisation, while monthly revenue increased tenfold between April 2023 and August 2024. Plastroots, a zero-landfill

waste-management venture, strengthened its financial and compliance systems to tap opportunities created by Extended Producer Responsibility regulations. It generated more than ₹3 crore from its EPR-compliance vertical in 12 months, recording fivefold growth while expanding beyond Maharashtra.

RCube Recycling refined its corporate pitch and shifted towards a business-to-business model for recycling printer cartridges.

A pilot with large chemicals company added more than ₹10 lakh to annual recurring revenue, while its fund-raising pitch attracted interest from six investment funds.

Top company officials have said the TechnoServe initiative has supported more than 300 businesses across 106 cities. Participants have recorded average revenue growth of 51 per cent, while 60 per cent of businesses onboarded are women-led, the Greenr's fact sheet says.



Europe besides exploring joint ventures with overseas companies.

### REVENUE, PROFIT UP

In FY26, the group reported consolidated revenue from operations of ₹5,075 crore, compared with ₹549 crore in FY25. Consolidated net profit increased to ₹185 crore (₹70 crore).

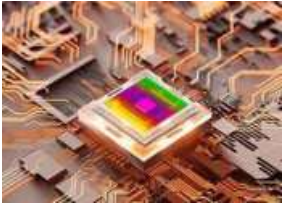
The acquisitions of Sunbridge Agro and Landsmill Agro have expanded Elitecon's presence across refining, storage, port-linked infrastructure and distribution in the edible-oil and agro-processing value chain.

The company is expanding refining and processing capacity at its Kandla and Mathura facilities while strengthening storage and distribution networks. The expansion is aimed at meeting domestic demand and creating capacity for export markets.

Elitecon said international expansion and capacity building across tobacco and edible oil would remain key components of its growth strategy.

QUICKLY.

Qualcomm, Apple extend chip licence agreement



**Bengaluru:** Qualcomm said on Thursday it has extended its licensing agreement for chips with Apple, effective April 1 next year. The partnership between the two companies has been shaped by a 2019 settlement that ended a two-year global legal battle over wireless-patent royalties and modem-chip supply. They announced the truce in April 2019 as a US jury trial between them was beginning in San Diego. Under the settlement, Apple made an undisclosed payment to Qualcomm, the companies dropped litigation worldwide and agreed to a six-year global patent licencing deal from April 1, 2019. The agreement gave Apple an option to extend the licence by two years. The firms did not comment on the details of the agreement. REUTERS

Genesys bags ₹283 crore 3D digital map contract

**New Delhi:** Geospatial technology company Genesys International Corporation on Thursday said it has secured a ₹283 crore World Bank-funded contract to develop a comprehensive geographic information system (GIS) 3D digital map platform for Ahmedabad. The project will cover approximately 625 square kilometres of Ahmedabad, digitally mapping the city's land parcels, properties, roads, water networks, sewerage systems, storm water drainage infrastructure, and other critical civic assets. It is expected to be completed by two-and-a-half years, followed by five years of maintenance. m

Tech funding reaches \$10.3 b in first 9 months of 2026, led by AI, lending and payments

Our Bureau  
Bengaluru

India's tech companies raised a combined \$10.3 billion in the first nine months of 2026 marking a 7 per cent increase over the \$9.7 billion raised in the same period a year earlier, and 3 per cent above the \$10 billion raised in 9M 2024, according to data by intelligence platform Tracxn.

This comes at a time when the number of funding rounds, first-time funded companies, and new Unicorn additions all declined sharply.

Enterprise applications, fintech and enterprise infrastructure emerged as the top-performing sectors, together anchored by 18 rounds of \$100 million or more, most notably Nxta's \$1 billion private-equity round for data-centre expansion.

India tech recorded 1,134 funding rounds in 9M 2026, down 38 per cent from 1,838 a year earlier, even as total dollars raised rose 7 per cent to \$10.3 billion.

A major share of these mega-rounds came from AI infrastructure, digital lending and payments — the clearest sign that capital is consolidating into fewer, larger, higher-conviction bets.

IGL eyes acquisition route to expand domestic, foreign markets footprint

**NETWORK GROWTH.** 70 new CNG stations take network to 1,024; board suggests final dividend of ₹1.5 a share

Our Bureau  
New Delhi

State-run Indraprastha Gas (IGL) on Thursday said that it is exploring acquisition of stake in existing city gas distribution (CGD) companies in a bid to expand its footprint by acquiring or buying stake in other CGD companies in the domestic market.

The company, which operates CGD networks across 33 districts in 12 geographical areas across Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Rajasthan, is also eyeing foreign markets for expanding its network.

**RECORD GAS SALES**  
Addressing the shareholders at its 27th Annual General Meeting, Subhankar Sen, Chairman of IGL, said the PSU is exploring acquisition of stake in existing CGD companies.

In its FY26 annual report,



Subhankar Sen (centre), Chairman of IGL, at the company's AGM

the company said, “We continue to explore potential acquisitions of complementary CGD companies and assess strategic investment opportunities as they emerge in the market. Your company is also exploring international opportunities for CGD expansion and other related business segments.

The country's largest CNG distribution company achieved its highest ever av-

erage CNG sales of 50 lakh kg per day and the highest ever industrial sales of 1 million standard cubic meters per day (mscmd) in the last financial year.

It also achieved record gas sales volume of 9.39 mscmd in FY26 with cumulative volume hitting 3,427.21 million standard cubic meters.

Sen said that FY26 presented significant challenges for the global energy sector.

Geopolitical tensions, particularly in West Asia, and disruptions in important energy supply routes created uncertainty in global energy markets. Despite these challenges, IGL achieved good sales volume and profitability, he noted.

**NEW CNG STATIONS**

Sen informed the shareholders that IGL set up 70 new CNG stations during the year, taking the total number to 1,024.

The company also added more than 3.70 lakh new PNG domestic connections and increased the commercial and industrial customer base significantly.

Sen also gave an overview of the company's future plans regarding exploring the use of renewable energy in place of conventional grid power, which will be a step towards carbon emission reduction and net zero.

IGL has signed a joint ven-

ture agreement with Rajasthan Vidyut Utpadan Nigam for setting up a green-field solar power plant of 500 megawatt-peak capacity and has also floated a tender for setting up a solar plant of 200 MW in Rajasthan.

The government's GOBARdhan initiative can complement the CGD network and contribute to reducing the carbon intensity of the energy mix, he added.

As part of backward integration, the company has set up a JV company, IGL Genesis Technologies, for meter manufacturing. Recently, commercial production of meters has started. All these initiatives would add to the future growth of the company.

IGL's board of directors has recommended a final dividend of 75 per cent (₹1.5 per share) besides payment of 162.5 per cent (₹3.25 per share) interim dividend for FY26.

India plans for 26.3 GW data centre load as AI reshapes power strategy

Amit Vijay Mohile  
Mumbai



As India's AI economy fires up demand for grid-based electricity, the Ministry of Power has nearly doubled its estimate of additional data centre load to 26.3 GW by 2031-32 from an earlier 13.56 GW, prompting policy and energy experts on Wednesday to call for demand-response regulations and green tariffs that integrate these power-hungry facilities more closely with renewable energy and the grid.

About 17 GW of connectivity applications have already been filed with state transmission utilities, while the additional data centre load could help push India's peak electricity demand beyond 388 GW by 2031-32. Rather than meeting the emerging peak simply by adding generation capacity, experts want data centres to become more flexible power consumers as renewable generation expands.

**DEMAND RESPONSE**

“Data centres have significant potential to provide demand-response services to the electricity grid, particularly as the share of renewable energy increases and demand becomes more variable,” Vishal Tripathi, consultant at the Council on Energy, Environment & Water, said at a Policy Consensus Centre webinar.

“Instead of building additional generation capacity simply to meet peak demand, demand response can become an important part of the solution,” he said.

Tripathi said States need regulatory frameworks to unlock demand response.

Distribution companies also need green tariffs aligned with evolving corporate renewable-energy procurement and Scope 2 accounting requirements. Such

tariffs could give data centres greater access to renewable electricity while creating an additional revenue opportunity for utilities.

**INDIA'S CAPACITY**

The stakes are rising quickly. India's data centre capacity is projected to reach 6-6.5 GW by 2030, while another industry estimate puts the development pipeline through the end of the decade at 3,860 MW, requiring nearly \$29.9 billion in capital.

NASSCOM called for States to create integrated district- and cluster-level resource maps covering power, water, land, fibre, roads and other infrastructure, rather than keeping such information fragmented across government departments. “We need comprehensive information integrated at the cluster and district level in the form of resource maps,” said Sudipto Banerjee, Deputy Director, Public Policy, at NASSCOM.

He said the maps should be matched with a database tracking data centre projects from announcement to commissioning, allowing investors, operators and governments to assess an area's carrying capacity before deciding where facilities should be built.

The proposals bring together three infrastructure build-outs and they are AI computing, renewable-energy generation and the electricity grid.

‘Firms facing labour code compliance challenges’

Our Bureau  
Chennai

Even as India's new labour codes move from being a compliance exercise to implementation, companies are facing various challenges as they make this transition.

Ten months after the labour codes took effect, there is still considerable ambiguity around wages definition, worker classification, payroll and contract labour forcing changes to HR systems, and others, according to a new Grant Thornton Bharat (GT Bharat) report.

“Although implementa-

tion challenges vary by industry, workforce composition and operating model, several common priorities have emerged from industry interactions, implementation engagements and stakeholder discussions,” the consulting firm said in its new report titled ‘India's new labour codes: From reform to readiness’.

For instance, the definition of wages has attracted the greatest attention from both employers and employees, as it influences provident fund contributions, gratuity, statutory bonus, overtime payments, leave encashment and sev-

eral other employment-related obligations, the report notes.

**NEW LABOUR CODE**

Businesses are also having to align attendance, payroll and HR systems with requirements relating to working hours and overtime, leading to procedural and systemic changes.

The new labour codes also require the settlement of dues within two working days of separation, pushing organisations to better implement full and final settlement systems.

Women's employment provisions also require oper-

ational changes. Employers need to build consent, safety and transportation arrangements for women working before 6 am or after 7 pm, while also addressing *creche*-related requirements.

**FOUR CODES**

As companies implement the labour codes, it has prompted closer reviews of attendance systems, leave administration and payroll processes, the GT Bharat consultants note. To implement the four codes effectively, organisations must map wages accurately, assess coverage at the employee level and maintain robust

payroll controls, it adds.

Tracking progress across States, the report notes that labour and employment matters fall within the Concurrent List under the Constitution, and thus State-level rule-making is integral to the implementation of the labour codes.

“Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Dadra and Nagar Haveli, Gujarat, Lakshadweep and Puducherry have implemented final rules under all four codes. Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Punjab have finalised the rules under one or more codes,” it said.

RBI warns banks against relaxed FCNR(B) underwriting

Our Bureau  
Mumbai

With the banking system having excess liquidity due to the limited-period foreign currency non-resident (bank) or FCNR(B) deposit-related swap facility offered by RBI, central bank officials told banks not to compromise on underwriting standards in their quest for higher returns.

Banks collectively mopped up a whopping \$133 billion *via* 3-5 year FCNR(B) deposits between June 8 and August 31 under the RBI's special USD-INR Forex Swap facility.

Under the swap, banks gave RBI dollars and received equivalent amount of rupee liquidity.

The RBI is absorbing the surplus liquidity from the banking system *via* variable rate reverse repo auction and open market operation sale of government securities.

Banks could avail RBI's swap facility for the FCNR (B) deposits mobilised by them till September 11. As of this date, excess liquidity in the banking system stood at ₹10,72,702 crore.

BlueBinaries to buy MicroNova's automotive testing business

Rohan Das  
Chennai



Kishore LM, Founder and COO of BlueBinaries

BlueBinaries, a company that offers software and engineering services for the mobility industry, will acquire the automotive testing business of Germany-based MicroNova AG.

The acquisition will bring MicroNova's expertise in test systems, especially hardware-in-the-loop (HIL) systems, into the BlueBinaries fold, while also increasing its customer base and team strength.

HIL systems allow real electrical components in a vehicle to be tested using computer simulation of the automobile.

Speaking to *businessline*, Kishore LM, Founder and COO of BlueBinaries, said with the acquisition, BlueBinaries aims to scale MicroNova's technology globally and become a stronger player in the HIL systems market, estimated to be over \$2 billion by 2032.

**REVENUE GROWTH**

He added that the deal will be funded by a combination of both existing and new in-

vestors, and is expected to close in the next 60 days. He did not reveal the deal amount, citing non-disclosure agreements with MicroNova AG.

BlueBinaries is expecting to close FY27 with a topline of \$25-30 million, which, after adding the \$20 million business from MicroNova is expected to push the company's total revenue for the year above \$50 million.

BlueBinaries has grown around 15-22 per cent annually over the past 2-3 years and has a long-term target of

hitting \$100 million in revenue over the next three to four years.

**POST ACQUISITION**

The acquisition will also offer cross-selling opportunities for the company. “With both BlueBinaries and MicroNova's testing business, we now are in a position to offer end-to-end testing services to both our customers,” he said.

Post the acquisition, the company plans to carve out business as a separate company within the BlueBinaries group under the new name NovaBinaries GmbH.

**LONG-TERM GOAL**

Over the long-term, BlueBinaries is also evaluating entering into other industries beyond automotive with aerospace, industrial automation and robotics identified as possible options.

The company has a team of around 550 engineers spread across offices in India, UK, Germany and Austria with plans to add another 60-80 people over the next 12-18 months.

Complex AI threats increasing stress levels of cybersecurity professionals

Rohan Das  
Chennai

As AI makes attacks more sophisticated and increases the volume of cybersecurity work, so has the stress levels of cybersecurity professionals.

A latest report from ISACA, a global professional body focused on IT governance and cybersecurity, suggests that over 59 per cent of Indian employees working in the domain report a significant increase in stress levels compared to five years ago, as against the

global average of 68 per cent.

The report collected insights from over 1,800 cybersecurity professionals around the world, including 147 in India. The increasingly complex threat landscape, primarily due to AI-driven malicious attacks, is the primary contributor to increasing stress levels, with more than two-thirds the surveyed employees attributing it as the main stressor.

**SOLVE PROBLEMS**

RV Raghun, ISACA Ambassador & Director, Versatilis Consulting India, said com-

panies should focus on expanding the pool of people who can work in cybersecurity.

“Enabling the people who are currently already in the system to relax and not collapse under the pressure is crucial. Enterprises must increase the universe of people who can help solve security problems,” he said.

**ADDRESSING BURNOUT**

Speaking to *businessline*, experts suggest that companies must address understaffed teams and burnout, alongside plugging skill gaps to

● **SKILL SHIELD**

Experts urge expanding the talent pool, upskilling, and smarter use of AI to ease workloads while shoring up security.

mitigate the pressure on cybersecurity teams.

Raghavendra B V, Partner and Deputy Leader, Cybersecurity Consulting firm EY India, suggests that while firms are leveraging AI to eliminate low-value work across cybersecurity opera-

tions, they must also invest heavily in reskilling and upskilling.

“Cybersecurity professionals are being trained to develop AI agents to improve cyber operations. They are also placing emphasis on plan work allocation, helping address headcount, automation, and well-being together, rather than treating them as separate,” he said.

**UNDERSTAFFED TEAMS**

ISACA's report also highlighted that 2 per cent of India-based cybersecurity teams are understaffed,

compared to 58 per cent globally. Attrition is also flagged as a challenge, with 66 per cent of the respondents in India admitting that their firms struggle to retain cyber talent, compared to 55 per cent last year.

Sanketh Chengappa, Director and Business Head, Professional Staffing, Adecco India, points to the staffing model in the domain evolving, with organisations combining core internal teams with specialised external talent, managed services and project-based expertise.



QUICKLY.

Upasana Konidela named Apollo's Director-Projects



**Chennai:** Upasana Kamineni Konidela has been designated as the Director – Projects at Apollo Hospitals. She will work with Apollo's leadership, clinical teams and project partners on the hospital projects across India, the company said on Thursday. Apollo's current expansion plan has an estimated total project cost of approximately ₹8,600 crore, including approximately ₹1,565 crore of listed brownfield expansion projects worth ₹1,565 crore at existing facilities. **OUR BUREAU**

**Technopark clocks 17% rise in software exports**

**Kochi:** Technopark has registered a 17 per cent growth in its software export revenues in FY26 at ₹17,092 crore against ₹14,575 crore in FY25, said a press note. The campus has also evolved into a dynamic start-up ecosystem. **ODR BUREAU**

**SAIL CMD shares plans for 35 mt capacity target**

**New Delhi:** State-owned SAIL aims to meet its 35 million tonne capacity target by FY31 with increased share of value-added and special steels, and deeper integration with retail and MSME ecosystems, the company's Chairman and Managing Director A K Panda said on Thursday. SAIL, a PSU under the Ministry of Steel, is India's largest public sector steel company having an overall capacity of over 20 mt. The company is implementing expansion plans across its five integrated steel projects. **PII**

## Gen Z opens its wallet for festivals, but keeps its research hat on: Report

**Our Bureau**  
Bengaluru

India's Gen Z is opening up its wallet during the festive season, but it is not necessarily shopping on impulse. While six in 10 young consumers said they spend more during festivals, their purchase is increasingly marked by research, comparison and a degree of scepticism towards what they see online, according to a report by Rukam Capital in collaboration with YouGov.

Family remains at the heart of festive spending, accounting for 74 per cent of gifting, while self-gifting has also emerged as a significant part of the season.

Nearly a third of Gen Z consumers say their festive spending is planned in advance.

The shift is particularly visible in how they discover

# Modi, Shah should be investigated for ‘vote theft’ conspiracy: Rahul Gandhi

**MOUNTING IRE.** Cong to move impeachment motion against CEC; CJP demands Gyanesh Kumar steps down

**Dalip Singh**  
New Delhi

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Thursday said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah should be investigated for their conspiracy to steal votes and called them “*desh drohis*” (anti-national) for attacking the democratic structure of India.

He, however, advised Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, who is at the centre of controversy, to become “an approver” in the alleged vote theft scandal.

The BJP dubbed Congress attack as a bundle of lies, dubbing it as “*jhoot ki goonz*” (repeated lying) by a frustrated leader.

Gandhi's press conference, where he announced the party's plan to escalate

protests against alleged irregularities in revision of electoral rolls across States, was followed by Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) threatening a nationwide agitation, “Jantar Mantar 2.0”, if Gyanesh Kumar does not step down within 48 hours. The CJP described him as “anti-national”.

**CJP LASHES OUT** Addressing reporters, CJP's Saurav Das demanded the immediate resignation and launch of criminal investigation against Kumar, as he alleged that the electoral process had been “rigged” to take away the right to vote from citizens; all coming elections should be put on hold and the voters list rolled back to the January 2025 voter list, prior to the Special Intensive Revision.

“Constitute an independent inquiry commission that will inspire public confidence and examine all the decision-making processes related to the SIR,” Das urged.



**CHARGED UP.** Lok Sabha LoP and Congress MP Rahul Gandhi addresses a press conference at Indira Bhawan, in New Delhi **ANI**

ence and examine all the decision-making processes related to the SIR,” Das urged.

Holding the Supreme Court “equally culpable”, he said “We also demand that all files related to SIR and all files concerning the decision-making process of the SIR be immediately seized and placed in the Court's custody,” he noted.

**‘FLAWED PROCESS’** “Repeal the 2023 law on the

appointment of the Election Commissioners of India and enact a new law that inspires public confidence, with the active participation of members of civil society”, was his third demand.

Meanwhile, Rahul Gandhi said he and his party feel vindicated since their stand from 2023 has now been vindicated by two Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

## ‘Karnataka in SC: Doing our best on Cauvery water sharing’

**Krishnadas Rajagopal**  
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought Karnataka's response to a Tamil Nadu plea that it is suffering a shortfall of 20 thousand million cubic feet (TMC) Cauvery river water supply.

Karnataka, in turn, submitted in the apex court that it was facing a “terrible drought situation”, and, as an upper riparian State has complied to the best its responsibilities towards Tamil Nadu.

“Karnataka is usurping all the water, depriving us of our

own,” senior advocate CS Vaidyanathan, for Tamil Nadu, submitted.

**ONE WEEK NOTICE** Senior advocate Shyam Divan, for Karnataka, said entire districts in the State have been declared as drought-prone. “Yet we have taken it on the chin and done our best to comply,” he submitted.

The court gave Karnataka a week to file its response while scheduling the case for October 12.

Vaidyanathan, accompanied by senior advocate G Umaphy, complained that both the Cauvery Water Reg-

ulation Committee (CWRC) and the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) have not addressed the deficit of Cauvery water due to Tamil Nadu from Karnataka.

“They are directing the release of only low quantities. Karnataka has a sizeable quantity,” Vaidyanathan submitted. He said Tamil Nadu's kharif crop had been affected.

**TN LOSING OUT** He said Karnataka had realised 112.729 TMC between June 1 and September 9.

“They have also drawn 19.349 TMC through the canals in the four reservoirs;

3.9 TMC through Anicut channels; and 3.962 TMC through diversion in the Kabini Dam.

The total yield in Karnataka is 140 TMC... I should have got at least 57 per cent of the 97.408 TMC the Tamil Nadu is usually entitled to receive in normal conditions. That would come to 59.191 TMC. But we have realised only 35 TMC. There is a deficit of 20.969 TMC,” Vaidyanathan submitted.

He said the monsoon has receded. There may not be any further rainfall.

“They (Karnataka) have water in their reservoirs.

Why is my shortfall not being made good?” Vaidyanathan said.

Divan, along with senior advocate Mohan Katarki, submitted, “The CWRC/ CWMA are monitoring. They have discussed everything in detail, including the live storage position of the designated reservoirs in Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, the declining trend in the gross inflows into the four reservoirs of Karnataka, data, the rainfall activity in the next fortnight, drinking water flow, industrial and environmental flow, El Nino... Every factor is being considered,” Divan said.

## Housing societies tap into residential rooftop solar to save on electricity bill

**Rishi Ranjan Kala**  
New Delhi



Resident welfare associations (RWAs) and Group Housing Societies (GHS) are actively installing roof top solar power installations adding roughly 278MW capacity led by Gujarat, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu.

Cumulatively, under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana (PMSG: MBY) more than 19,000 RWAs and GHS spread across tier-I, -II and -III cities have installed rooftop solar installations covering over nine lakh households.

Tier-I cities and clusters such as Ahmedabad, Mumbai, Pune, Nagpur, Bengaluru, Ranga Reddy, Chennai and Medchal-Malkajgiri are showing a growing interest in rooftop solar. Similarly, Tier II cities such as Coimbatore, Sri Potti Srimamulu Nellore (Nellore), Visakhapatnam, Kolhapur and Nashik are also catching up.

An official explained that even as the momentum in tier III cities is slow, there is a growing interest, particularly among societies, which are eying RTS installations with the intent to save power bills and utilise solar for day-time consumption.

Tier III cities and regions such as Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, Navsari, Morbi, Palghar and Valsad are gradually evincing interest in RTS power.

**TOP STATES** State-wise, Gujarat leads in installations with 9,377 housing societies setting up 106.18 MW of solar capacity and benefiting around 3.54 lakh households. Maharashtra, which occupies the second spot, recorded 7,594 RWAs collectively installing 138.99 MW capacity benefit-

ing roughly 4.28 lakh households. Other States are also steadily expanding their adoption of community solar. Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh have implemented it across 640, 273 and 248 RWAs, respectively.

Ahmedabad (3,499 RWAs) leads the tally in terms of cities driving RTS installations in RWAs and GHS across India followed by Pune (3,412 societies), Vadodara (1,741 societies), Nashik (1,562 societies), and Surat (1,426 societies).

The government has disbursed around ₹422.30 crore in central subsidy, with final subsidy transfers having been completed for RWAs. To make community-scale rooftop solar financially viable, the government also provides Central Financial Assistance (CFA) of ₹18,000 per kW for eligible RWAs and GHS projects.

With common-area electricity bills forming a significant component of monthly maintenance expenses in many large housing complexes, the government's support for rooftop solar is creating a new avenue for societies to reduce recurring costs while transitioning to cleaner energy.

From individual rooftops to entire residential communities, PM Surya Ghar is helping turn India's housing societies into collective clean-energy hubs cutting electricity costs while bringing solar power closer to everyday urban life.

## SC reserves orders on Centre's plea for two-year window to fix OBC creamy layer policy

**Krishnadas Rajagopal**  
New Delhi



The Supreme Court on Thursday reserved orders on a Centre's plea seeking prospective operation of a March 11, 2026 judgment to re-assess OBC non-creamy layer status as per a 1993 Office Memorandum by excluding parental salary income and agricultural income from the income/wealth test.

A Bench of Justices PS Narasimha and R Mahadevan heard the application filed by the Centre, represented by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta and Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, which also sought a “reasonable time” of two years to undertake the necessary exercise of establishing equivalence of posts, after consulting stakeholders and formulating an appropriate and uniform policy/mechanism for de-

termination of OBC creamy layer status.

**PROSPECTIVE EFFECT** “The Court has power under Article 142 of the Constitution to declare its judgment prospective. If the judgment is not given prospective effect, it will entail several harsh and unjust unintended consequences on employees/appointees who were not even parties to the litigation and complete administrative chaos. It is therefore prayed

that the judgment (*Union of India vs Rohith Nathan*) be given prospective effect so that ongoing and past recruitment processes are not affected,” the Centre urged.

Bhati submitted that an implementation of the March 11 judgment, particularly with retrospective effect, may affect allocation of services since 2012. The implementation of the judgment currently would not only affect admissions in higher educational institutions and but also candidates involved in ongoing examinations/recruitment processes post the judgment. Bhati said an immediate move would have consequences on OBC reservation policy across the country.

She said the government required sufficient time for determination of a new policy to correct hostile discrimination as pointed out

by the court in the judgment.

Senior advocate P Wilson, who represents the candidates, objected while contending that the Centre was merely trying to delay, even undo a final judgment of the apex court. He criticised that the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) had failed to comply with court directions, Parliamentary Committee recommendations, and its own 1993 rules. He said the government could very well create supernumerary posts to accommodate eligible OBC candidates.

In its judgment, the court had directed the DoPT to create supernumerary posts within six months to accommodate eligible Other Backward Castes-Non-Creamy Layer (OBC-NCL) candidates who were wrongfully denied service allocations due to improper creamy layer classification.

## Rajasthan bets ₹3,000 cr on mass-premium tourism, looks beyond palace hotels to create experiences

**Amit Vijay Mohile**  
Mumbai

A three-day wedding that can cost ₹2.5-5 crore in Rajasthan's luxury palaces is now getting a ₹35-70 lakh alternative, while a room costing ₹25,000-30,000 a night could be replaced by a ₹8,500-12,000 stay for a family of four, without sacrificing the forts, havelis, desert landscapes, cuisine, music and culture that attract visitors to Rajasthan.

Driving this shift is about ₹3,000 crore worth of tourism projects under execution. Travel and hospitality expert Sheldon Santwan told *businessline* that the trend was clearly visible at the Rajasthan Domestic Travel Mart (RDTM) held in Jaipur on September 17-19, where weddings and events were

formally incorporated into the platform for the first time. According to Santwan, around 41 wedding planners participated alongside travel buyers. The industry also renewed its demand for extending the Delhi-Jodhpur Vande Bharat service to Jaisalmer.

“Udaipur and Jaipur are sold out nearly 10 months in advance for peak wedding dates. By connecting event planners directly with lesser-known heritage properties in destinations such as Ghanerao and Shekhawati, we are creating an entirely new mid-luxury price band of ₹40-70 lakh,” Santwan said.

**THE 45% SHIFT** “Travellers want Rajasthani music, cuisine, culture, forts and desert dunes. The opportunity lies in delivering that



**HOSPITALITY PUSH.** Rajasthan is expected to add an estimated 12,000-15,000 branded hotel rooms by FY30

experience at ₹8,500-12,000 a night instead of ₹25,000-30,000.” Rajasthan is expected to add an estimated 12,000-15,000 branded hotel rooms by FY30, with nearly 60 per cent of the pipeline located outside Jaipur, Udaipur and Jodhpur.

Mass-premium and mid-market hotels account for an estimated 45 per cent of proposed inventory, compared

with 25 per cent in the upper-upscale and premium segment, 20 per cent in luxury and ultra-luxury properties, and 10 per cent in budget hotels.

Tourism-related Memoranda of Understanding signed under the Rising Rajasthan initiative total about ₹1.38 lakh crore. Former Federation of Hospitality and Tourism of Rajasthan

(FHTR) President Kuldeep Singh Chandela said havelis in Shekhawati and Bundi are increasingly being restored and converted into tourism assets, while destinations such as Banswara and Rajasthan's desert interior are also receiving greater attention.

**MISSING LINK** “Corporate clients no longer want conventional hotel ballrooms for offsites. They are increasingly seeking heritage-meets-nature experiences,” Santwan said.

“Rajasthan is growing, and domestic tourism numbers have remained encouraging,” FHTR President Surendra Singh Shahpura said, “Stronger rail and air connectivity is essential for destinations such as Jodhpur and Jaisalmer.”

## Telangana targets 5 GW hyperscale data centre capacity by 2029

**KV Kurmanath**  
Hyderabad

Telangana is targeting to build 5 GW of data centre capacity by 2029, with around \$30 billion in potential investment across the broader AI and digital infrastructure ecosystem. The State has over 300 MW of data-centre operational and 2 GW under development across major global and Indian operators such as Microsoft, AWS, Iron Mountain, CtrlS, Sify, and NTT DATA.

“What is significant is the shift in the nature of this capacity, as new projects are increasingly being designed around AI-scale compute, high-density GPUs, hyperscale cloud, and advanced cooling, rather than conventional enterprise data-centre requirements,” Telangana IT

and Industries Minister said after inaugurating Microsoft's South Central Cloud Region, a data centre complex, here on Thursday.

The South Central Cloud Region, is part of Microsoft's \$20.5-billion cloud and data centre expansion plan for India. It comprises three Availability Zones built with a ‘re-

silient’ design aligned to the country's regulatory and seismic-zone requirements to support mission critical workloads at scale.

The inauguration of the facility follows Microsoft's announcement in New Delhi earlier this week that its India South Central region is now live.

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QUICKLY.

Meta debuts camera-free smart-glasses



Meta Platforms is expanding its smart-glasses line-up with camera-free models, support for the popular new Muse assistant and a hearing-aid mode. At its Connect conference Wednesday, the social media giant unveiled the Ray-Ban Meta Audio, its first pair of glasses without cameras. The company also introduced a third-generation model of its camera-equipped Ray-Ban spectacles and new versions of its more affordable Meta-branded frames. Meta and the broader smart-glasses industry have faced concerns that the devices' cameras can record people without their consent. Chief Technology Officer Andrew Bosworth said audio-only glasses were added to their product road map two years ago and removing cameras allowed them to reduce the price and weight while extending battery life.

Sarvam founder calls for leveraging AI to fend off global tech monopolies

Our Bureau  
Chennai

India risks turning into a 'digital colony' if we continue to build applications and services that run on technology that is controlled by a handful of global companies, according to Pratyush Kumar, Co-Founder and CEO, Sarvam AI.

Speaking at a fireside chat at SaaS major Zoho's annual Zoholics conference here on Thursday, Kumar said that AI gives India the opportunity to make up for the lost ground and we should "jump with both hands and legs" to set it right.

"We have been too complacent in this country for far too long, building thin layers on top of things others have created. Let us say you are a large enough company today,

FSSAI notifies draft rules in move to ban analogue paneer

**SURVEILLANCE.** Proposed regulations come amid intensified dairy adulteration checks

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani  
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) is gearing up to prohibit manufacturing and sale of analogue *paneer* at a pan-India level and has notified draft amendments for stakeholder consultation.

This comes as several State governments have already banned the sale and manufacturing of analogue *paneer*.

**FOCUS ON CRACKDOWN**

The food safety authority, which has been focusing on a crackdown on violations along with State FDAs, has expressed concerns regarding the sale of analogue *paneer* in the country.

Analogue *paneer* refers to a product where ingredients not derived from milk replace some or all of the milk components, resulting in a product that mimics the



**SAFETY FIRST.** FSSAI said the proposal seeks to safeguard consumer interests and ban marketing of analogue *paneer*

sensory and functional properties of *paneer*.

FSSAI has decided to introduce draft amendments in the Food Safety and Standards (Prohibition and Restrictions on Sales) regulations. "The amendment is proposed to restrict manufacturing and sale of analogue product as *paneer* so as to prevent misleading of

consumer's regarding the nature and composition of the product," the draft notification stated.

The draft notification added that products already licensed or registered under 'analogue in dairy context' category will need to discontinue the use of the term '*paneer*' in their nomenclature, labelling or market-

ing. "These regulations may be called the Food Safety and Standards (Prohibition and Restrictions on Sales) Amendment Regulations, 2026," it added.

FSSAI said the proposal seeks to safeguard consumer interests and ban the practice of marketing analogue products such as *paneer*.

Several states have already banned manufacture, storage, sale and distribution of analogue *paneer* for nearly one year.

These include Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand.

**FESTIVAL SEASON**

Ahead of the festival season, FSSAI has also directed States to ramp up surveillance and inspections to prevent adulteration especially for dairy and dairy-related products, which witness an increase in demand.

Milky Mist to revise product claims, packaging

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani  
New Delhi

With the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) initiating action against some online platforms over sale of three products of Milky Mist Dairy Food Ltd found to be having non-compliant product information, the company said it has "initiated revisions".

"Milky Mist Dairy Food Ltd received a notice from FSSAI seeking clarification on certain product claims, packaging representations and product information. We have submitted our response and initiated revisions to the relevant packaging and artwork, as well as updates to product information and images on e-commerce platforms," a company spokesperson told *businessline*.

Pixxel plans at least four satellite launches in 2028 under its ₹1,200 cr programme

Jyoti Banthia  
Bengaluru

Space-tech start-up Pixxel plans to launch at least four satellites in 2028 as part of its ₹1,200 crore National Earth Observation Constellation programme, as the company steps up investments in satellite infrastructure while targeting near-doubling revenue growth almost every year.

Pixxel will directly execute around 60-70 per cent of the programme, translating into an investment of about ₹700-750 crore over the next three-and-a-half years, Co-founder and Chief Executive Awais Ahmed said in an interaction with *businessline*.

The company expects the first satellites under the programme to be launched in early 2028, with all 12 satel-



lites targeted to be deployed by 2030. Pixxel expects at least four satellites to be launched during 2028.

"It is a ₹1,200 crore programme. We will be doing 60 to 70 per cent of it from Pixxel directly. So that is ₹700-ish, ₹750-ish crore over the next four years. Three and a half years now," Ahmed said.

**KEY DIFFERENTIATOR**

The National Earth Observation Constellation is expected to expand Pixxel's capabilities beyond hyperspectral imaging to other forms of

Earth observation, including optical, synthetic aperture radar (SAR) and multispectral imaging.

Ahmed said the company's satellite platform and technology are largely common across different types of imaging satellites, with the payloads being the key differentiator. The company, which recently raised \$100 million in a Series C funding round, said the new capital would allow it to accelerate satellite launches and infrastructure investments rather than build the business from scratch.

"The plan is to make sure that we can keep doubling the growth almost every year and we have the contracts, the backlog to keep doing that," Ahmed said.

Pixxel currently serves around 35-40 customers through its Firefly satellites, with about 90 per cent of

these being commercial enterprises, while government customers account for a larger share of the company's revenue. Ahmed said government contracts account for about 75 per cent of revenue, with enterprises contributing the remaining 25 per cent.

The company expects the balance between its data, intelligence and satellite businesses to evolve as it scales.

Despite the capital-intensive nature of the space business, Pixxel expects to turn profitable next year. Ahmed said the company is currently spending heavily on satellites, with much of that expenditure expected to be completed by 2027.

"2028 should be a year where we actually also get to cash flow positivity because most of our space investments would have been finished by then," he said.

'Pharma revenue growth to accelerate 11-13% this fiscal'

Our Bureau  
New Delhi

Indian pharma revenue growth is expected to accelerate 11-13 per cent this fiscal from 8 per cent last year, driven by a 14-16 per cent rise in exports as drug-makers expand beyond the US into Europe, Asia, Africa and Latin America, ratings agency Crisil Intelligence has said.

The report said higher raw material, energy and freight costs are likely to put pressure on profitability, with operating margins expected to

contract by 150-200 basis points to 21-21.5 per cent, the analysis said.

The report prepared its assessment based on nearly 190 pharmaceutical companies rated by Crisil, which together account for about half of the sector's revenue.

**EXPORT GROWTH**

Exports are expected to be the key growth driver, with revenue from overseas markets projected to increase 14-16 per cent in rupee terms this fiscal. The sector derives nearly half of its revenue from exports, with formulations accounting for

about 83 per cent of these exports.

"Export growth is broadening beyond the US. Complex generics and biosimilars are expected to deepen the sector's presence in Europe, while branded generics and new launches will accelerate growth across Asia, Africa and Latin America," said Sehul Bhatt, Director, Crisil Intelligence.

Bhatt said that in the US, differentiated product launches and inventory normalisation are expected to partly offset continued pricing pressure. He added that a broader geographic and

product mix would drive export growth. According to the report, the domestic pharmaceutical market is also expected to expand 9-11 per cent this fiscal.

**KEY DRIVER**

Chronic therapies are likely to remain the main growth driver, supported by the increasing prevalence of lifestyle-related diseases.

Domestic growth will also be supported by annual price revisions of 5-6 per cent and a recovery in volume growth to 4-5 per cent, compared with around 2 per cent in each of the past two fiscals.

Novo looking to expand India portfolio with investments in new technologies

PT Jyothi Datta  
Mumbai

Danish healthcare company Novo Nordisk is open to invest in technologies that innovate, even personalise treatment for diabetes and obesity, said a top company executive.

Novo's globally-popular Ozempic and Wegovy, used in treating diabetes and obesity respectively – are both available in India.

"We are looking across the gamut of delivery in innovation, be it gene-based therapy or mRNA technology, for example," said Jay Thyagarajan, Novo Nordisk Senior Vice-President (APAC).

"So we are actually very open to looking at whatever the mechanism of actions that are available ...if we can actually complement the portfolio that we are build-



Jay Thyagarajan, Senior V-P (APAC), Novo Nordisk

ing internally within the company," Thyagarajan told *businessline*.

**TARGETED TREATMENT**

"We will have to move from mass treatment to more personalised, tailored medicine for obesity and diabetes into the future. And we are also looking at if we map the genomes of these patients, is there a way that we could actually target prevention, especially in childhood dia-

betes and childhood obesity," he said.

As they assess "every different platform", Thyagarajan said, AI and data integration in health further facilitate research into diagnosis, and prediction of diseases in a "more coordinated fashion that will give us more avenues for targeted treatment for specific diseases".

Novo Nordisk has recently been rebranded as Novo, even as its legal global company name remains Novo Nordisk A/S.

In India, the plan is to bring continuous innovation through partnerships, he said, adding that they were also looking at "co-manufacturing and co-developing in India ... to strengthen the footprint of India for India".

Supply chain and logistics are also on their radar, he said.

With a patent on Novo's

semaglutide, the active ingredient in Ozempic and Wegovy, expiring earlier this year in India, among other markets – a slew of domestic drugmakers entered the fray with their versions.

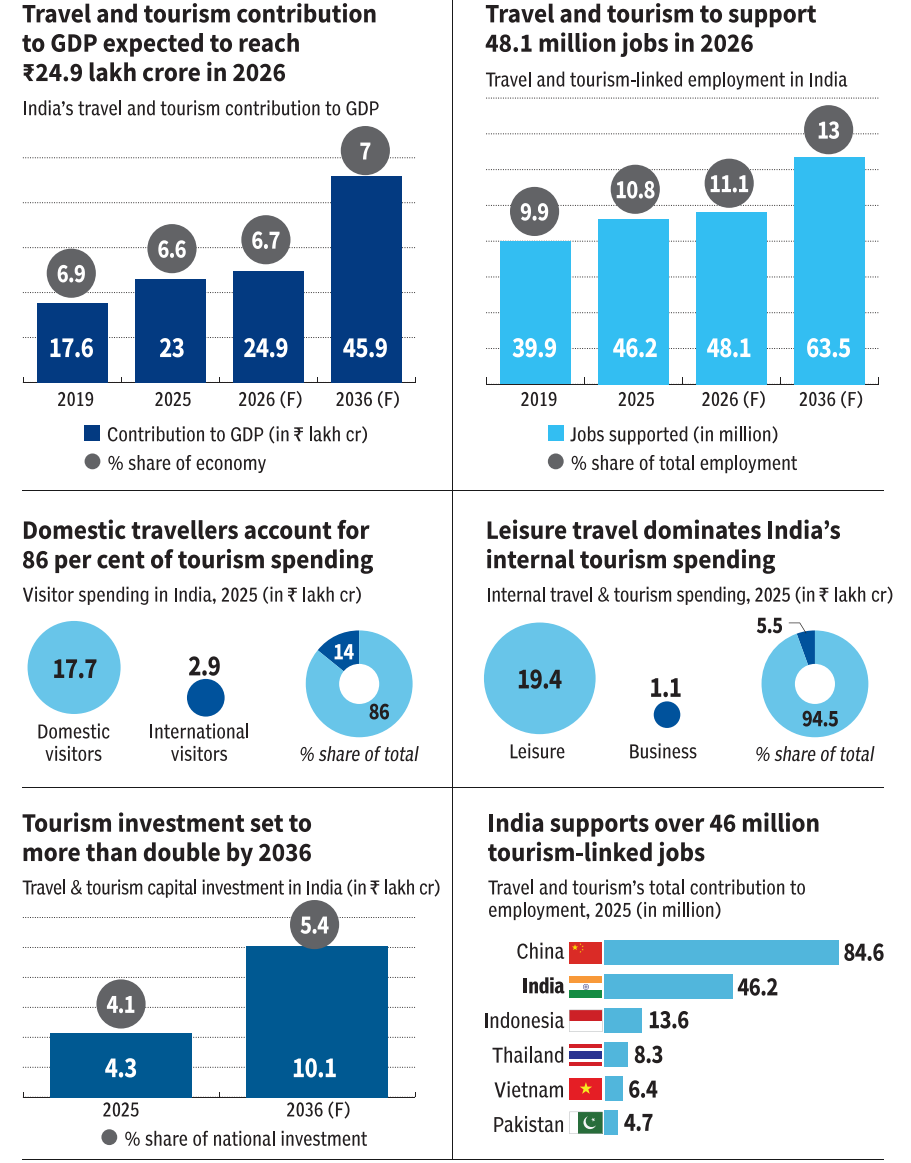
Thyagarajan said, "We have to bring innovative medicines, new ways of delivering the drugs to the patients, and that's the way we actually can progress both as a company, but also progress as a society that we live in."

"Patent expiry is an integral and natural part of the pharmaceutical product lifecycle that many companies go through," he said "Price does play a role in a sensitive market like India," he said.

In India, the partnerships are only going to grow, he said, adding, "We are in conversations with many companies now to see how we can actually expand this model as we speak."

VISUALLY.

Compiled by Yashaswani Chauhan | Graphic KS Gunasekar



Source: World Travel & Tourism Council's Economic Impact Research 2026

Trump hails 'truly great friendship' with Xi

Press Trust of India  
Washington

President Donald Trump on Thursday hailed the "truly great friendship" he has forged with Xi Jinping as the Chinese leader began his highly-anticipated state visit.

While Trump has many thorny issues to discuss with the President of America's biggest economic rival, he focused on his long relationship with Xi as the two gathered with aides for opening remarks before formal talks. "From the time of my



first election in 2016, President Xi and I have forged a friendship, a truly great friendship, actually, built on mutual respect and the vital interests of our people," Trump said.

**MAJOR ISSUES**

Trump and Xi have no shortage of difficult issues to

cover when they sit down for private talks. China has resisted the Trump administration's urgings to use its considerable leverage to prod Iran to agree to US terms to end the nearly seven-month war. Xi wants to see Trump permanently halt arms sales to Taiwan and loosen export restrictions on cutting-edge advanced chips.

The two sides agreed to extend by two months a trade truce that was set to expire November 10 as they work to find a more durable agreement.

Xi said the "competition should be a healthy one".



